



Weekly Insights | Feb 25, 2026

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Executive Summary

Corn – Exports Now Running Ahead of What the Balance Sheet Requires

Corn firmed into early March, with May settling near \$4.49, up about six cents on the week, as shipments continue to run ahead of seasonal requirements. Weekly inspections moderated to 1.86 MMT but pushed cumulative shipments to 39.6 MMT, now 45 percent ahead of last year, while roughly 75 percent of USDA's 83.83 MMT export forecast is already sold. With the four-week shipment average near 1.54 MMT versus a required 0.80 MMT pace through August, demand is beating what the balance sheet needs at this point in the calendar. Even so, the March–May spread

holds near a 12-cent carry, still signaling comfortable nearby coverage. CIF Gulf barge basis eased to +85H from +92H last week, ethanol bids remain firm, and managed money stays meaningfully net short, supportive flow underneath a curve that still pays storage.

Wheat – Front-End Flips as Funds Cover into Persistent Black Sea Pressure

Chicago SRW's front end tightened sharply, with the March–May spread flipping into roughly a 4-cent inversion after carrying near 10 cents last week, even as May settled near \$5.80 and held only marginal gains week over week. Weekly inspections slowed to 0.34 MMT, yet cumulative shipments remain nearly 19 percent ahead of last year, and 93 percent of USDA's export projection is already committed. Russian 12.5 percent FOB wheat near \$234/MT continues to anchor global pricing at a meaningful discount to U.S. Gulf equivalents, limiting sustained competitiveness. Managed money moved from a net short into a modest net long position, suggesting short covering contributed to the structural tightening. While exports remain steady, the inversion appears more positioning-driven than fundamentally restrictive, and absent a shift in global supply or pricing spreads, the broader balance sheet remains heavy.

Soybeans – Structure Firms Slightly as Brazil Expands Its Window

Soybeans recovered, with May settling near \$11.73, up roughly 15 cents on the week, though export flow remains seasonally subdued as Brazil accelerates shipments. Weekly inspections improved to 1.14 MMT, but cumulative shipments at 26.18 MMT remain 30 percent below last year, consistent with Brazil's expanding export program, with ANEC projecting March shipments near 15.7 MMT. The March–May spread narrowed to roughly a 10-cent carry, about 46 percent of full carry, down from 70 percent last week, suggesting stabilization in nearby structure rather than expanding storage incentives. CIF Gulf barge basis firmed modestly to +90H, and interior processor bids remain steady, reflecting continued domestic pull. Managed money remains net short, and while domestic demand continues to anchor the complex, Brazil's seasonal pricing ceiling remains firmly in place.

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(Carry percent calculated assuming 7 percent annual interest and \\$.05/bu per month storage/insurance cost over the spread interval.)

Macro / Policy – Ethanol Softens Slightly as Dollar Remains a Headwind

The U.S. dollar remained firm through the week, preserving a modest competitiveness headwind across export channels. Crude oil held relatively stable in the low-to-mid \$60s per barrel range, offering limited directional influence on biofuel margins. Ethanol production for the week ending February 27 declined to 1.095 million barrels per day from 1.113 previously, while stocks increased to 26.34 million barrels from 25.40. The combination points to steady grind activity but limited margin expansion, particularly as cash corn premiums remain firm across parts of the Midwest. Macro flows continue to play a secondary role relative to physical demand signals, with grain markets trading primarily on export execution and balance sheet mechanics rather than policy catalysts.

Weather – Argentina Stress Persists as U.S. Warms

NOAA's 6–10 day outlook continues to favor above-normal temperatures across much of the central United States, easing winter logistics friction and improving transportation conditions along major river corridors. Brazil's soybean harvest has reached roughly 45 percent completion, with safrinha planting progressing near 47 percent despite localized rainfall interruptions across parts of the north. Argentina remains the primary weather-sensitive variable, with soybean good-to-excellent ratings near 18 percent and corn near 26 percent. While scattered showers have provided partial relief, roughly one-quarter of the crop remains rated poor. Official production estimates remain unchanged near 47.5 MMT for soybeans and 55.0 MMT for corn, but yield sensitivity remains elevated as crops advance through key reproductive stages.

What's Next (Mar 5 – Mar 12):

Whether corn shipment pace continues to exceed required levels

Whether wheat inversion holds or relaxes back into carry

Whether soybean exports confirm demand despite Brazil's record March lineup

Argentina rainfall coverage during grain-fill

Table A – CME Futures (Front Contracts)

(Prices in USD per bushel, volume/open interest in contracts)

Contract (Front Month)	02/25/2026 Close	03/04/2026 Close	Change (Δ)	Δ percent	5-day Realized Vol* (x)	Open Interest Δ (x)
Corn (May '26)	\$4.43	\$4.49	+\$0.06	+1.41 percent	14 percent (ann.)	-9k (est.)
Soybeans (May '26)	\$11.58	\$11.73	+\$0.15	+1.29 percent	7 percent (ann.)	+16k (est.)
Wheat (May '26)	\$5.79	\$5.80	+\$0.01	+0.26 percent	26 percent (ann.)	-3k (est.)

5-day realized volatility estimated from daily settlement price changes.
Actual contract open interest changes are estimated.

Table B – Key Calendar Spreads & percent of Full Carry

Spread (Crop '25→'26)	02/25/2026 Quote	03/04/2026 Quote	Δ (carry)	percent Full Carry*	Market Implication
Corn Mar–May	+0.11\$	+0.12\$	+0.01	80 percent	Carry steady; storage economics intact
Soy Mar–May	+0.16\$	+0.10\$	-0.06	45 percent	Carry tightening; Brazil harvest pressure
Wheat Mar–May	+0.10\$	-0.04\$	-0.14	-25 percent	Nearby demand tightening; front-end inversion

Assumes 7 percent annual interest and \$0.05/bu per month storage/insurance. Estimated full carry over Mar–May (2 months): corn ≈ \$0.15, SRW wheat ≈ \$0.16, soybeans ≈ \$0.22. Percent of full carry = (calendar spread ÷ estimated full carry).

Table C – Notable International Futures (weekly moves, if significant):

Exchange (Front Month)	02/25/2026 USD Price	03/04/2026 USD Price	Δ percent	Notes
Dalian Corn (May)	¥2,398(\$8.55/bu)	¥2,422 (\$8.64/bu)	+1.00 percent	Tracking CBOT strength amid post-holiday industrial demand recovery
Dalian Soymeal (May)	¥2,847(\$393.18/mt)	¥2,823 (\$390.41/mt)	-0.84 percent	Seasonal pressure as South American soy supply enters the market
B3 (São Paulo) Corn (May)	R\$72.45 (\$13.78)	R\$73.58 (\$14.04)	+1.56 percent	Risk premium reflecting safrinha planting delays
Euronext Wheat (May)	€192.25 (\$223.75/mt)	€202.25 (\$235.39/mt)	+5.20 percent	Technical rebound amid tighter Black Sea export flows

Corn Market Deep Dive

Futures & Spreads: Corn futures advanced modestly on the week, with May settling near \$4.49 versus roughly \$4.43 last Wednesday, extending the recovery that began in late February. The more important signal remains in the curve: the March–May spread holds near a 12-cent carry, roughly 80 percent of full carry under the two-month storage framework. Carry widened slightly from last week's 11 cents, reinforcing that the market continues to reward storage and signal comfortable nearby coverage rather than front-end stress, even as the board firms. Realized volatility remains moderate near **14 percent annualized**, consistent with a market grinding higher rather than breaking into a higher-beta trend, and price action continues to reflect execution-driven support more than a structural tightening of supplies.

Funds & Positioning: Managed money remains net short in corn near -286,685 contracts as of the February 24 report, but the week featured meaningful short covering with a +103,702 contract improvement from the prior week. That shift matters because it confirms the rally is no longer only commercial-led; some speculative pressure is being relieved as execution stays strong. At the same time, open interest in May declined roughly 9,000 contracts from Feb 25 to Mar 3, suggesting the recent move has leaned more toward liquidation than aggressive new length. In other words, positioning remains defensive, but the market is starting to force risk reduction. Importantly, spreads have not collapsed despite the large remaining net short, indicating the market is absorbing speculative flow without signaling

tightening physical availability.

Cash & Basis: Cash markets cooled modestly after last week's strength but still read as constructive. CIF Gulf barge basis eased to roughly +85H from +92H, suggesting demand remains active but nearby offers are less urgent. Interior river bids are still running around 20 cents under **May**, and ethanol plants continue to post supportive bids to maintain nearby coverage. Basis is neither flashing scarcity nor rolling over; movement looks orderly, with barge economics still the main swing variable capable of quickly resetting Gulf values if river conditions tighten again.

Export Sales & Inspections: Export execution remains the anchor. Weekly inspections eased from last week's surge but stayed strong at 1.86 MMT for the week ending Feb 26, lifting cumulative shipments to 39.6 MMT, now 45 percent ahead of last year. Commitments stand near 62.96 MMT, equivalent to roughly 75 percent of USDA's 83.83 MMT export forecast already sold. Just as important, the four-week average shipment pace near 1.54 MMT sits well above the roughly 0.80 MMT required weekly pace to meet USDA's projection through August. That gap suggests the balance sheet has room for additional tightening if execution persists, even if weekly sales remain choppy.

Global Context: Global supply remains ample, but U.S. origin continues to hold competitive footing in core channels. Black Sea offers remain steady, and Argentine FOB values are currently cheaper into some destinations, but U.S. execution continues to be supported by dependable Western Hemisphere pull, particularly Mexico. Brazil remains focused on soybean logistics and safrinha development, limiting immediate corn export pressure in the near term. The global environment still caps runaway rallies, but the U.S. program is performing well enough that competition has not yet forced a structural deterioration in spreads or basis.

So What? Corn is firming while still trading like a carry market. The curve continues to reward storage, but export execution is running above what the balance sheet requires, and speculative shorts are being reduced rather than added. With May open interest drifting lower and managed money still meaningfully net short, the market retains a defensive overlay, yet downside pressure remains contained by physical flow and shipment momentum. Unless inspections materially cool or global competition sharpens, corn is increasingly set up to trade as a stable carry market with tightening risk skewed toward the USDA export line rather than toward a collapse in structure.

Soybean Market Deep Dive

Futures & Spreads: Soybean futures moved higher this week, with May settling near \$11.73 compared with roughly \$11.58 last Wednesday. The more notable shift occurred in the structure of the curve: the March–May spread tightened to roughly a 10 cent carry, equivalent to about 45 percent of full carry under the two-month storage framework. Last week's structure had widened toward 16 cents, so the compression signals that the market is no longer expanding storage incentives in response to Brazilian harvest pressure. Nearby coverage remains comfortable and the market is still clearly in contango, but the tightening spread suggests that the board is beginning to absorb seasonal supply rather than discount it further. Price action therefore reflects stabilization within a carry structure rather than a directional breakout.

Products & Crush: Domestic processing remains the primary source of underlying demand support for the soybean complex. Crushers remain well incentivized to operate at high utilization rates, though the margin structure is increasingly concentrated on the meal side of the balance sheet rather than on oil. Soybean oil inventories remain comfortable, limiting the contribution from the energy side of the complex, while steady feed demand continues to support meal pricing. The result is a processing sector that is maintaining throughput rather than accelerating it. In effect, crush demand is acting as a stabilizing force

that prevents Brazilian export pressure from translating into deeper weakness in the nearby market.

Cash & Basis: Cash markets remain stable and largely transactional rather than urgent. CIF Gulf barge basis is holding near +90H, firmer than recent lows but still consistent with routine export loading rather than a scramble for nearby coverage. Interior processor bids generally sit around 40 cents under May futures, reflecting balanced crusher coverage as plants maintain solid run rates without needing to step bids higher. With Brazil supplying the bulk of export demand during this window, basis behavior continues to read as “steady domestic pull” instead of tightening pipeline signals.

Funds & Positioning: Speculative positioning has shifted toward a more defensive posture. Managed Money is now net short roughly 171,000 contracts according to the February 24 CFTC report, a significant reversal from the constructive long positioning seen earlier in the winter. The build in short exposure reflects the market’s adjustment to Brazil’s dominant export window and the broader seasonal increase in global supply availability. Importantly, spreads have tightened despite the heavier speculative short exposure, suggesting that the market is absorbing positioning pressure without structural deterioration. The current configuration indicates a market that is defensively positioned but not collapsing under speculative weight.

Export Sales & Inspections: Export activity remains secondary while South America dominates global shipments. Weekly U.S. soybean inspections reached approximately 1.14 MMT for the week ending February 26, an improvement from earlier weeks but still leaving cumulative shipments near 26.18 MMT, roughly 30 percent below last year’s pace. Total export commitments stand around 35.65 MMT, or approximately 83 percent of USDA’s 42.87 MMT export projection. The remaining shipment requirement is manageable, and the recent pace suggests the United States can still meet the current forecast, but the trade rotation clearly favors Brazil during this portion of the marketing year. Export demand therefore remains functional, though it is no longer the primary driver of price formation.

Global Context: Brazil remains the defining force in the global soybean balance sheet. CONAB’s latest estimate places production near 178 MMT, confirming another record crop as harvest progresses across the central producing states. ANEC projects March soybean exports near 15.7 MMT, underscoring the scale of Brazilian logistics as export flows accelerate. FOB Santos offers remain competitively priced into Asia relative to U.S. Gulf values, reinforcing Brazil’s dominance during the peak shipping window. Argentina’s crop outlook remains closer to 47–48 MMT, though crop ratings remain historically weak after earlier heat stress and keep the market sensitive to late-season weather developments. For now, Brazil defines supply while Argentina represents the remaining weather variable.

So What? Soybeans appear to be transitioning from seasonal pressure toward stabilization. The board moved higher on the week and the March–May spread tightened materially, signaling that the market is beginning to absorb Brazilian harvest flow rather than expanding storage incentives. Domestic processing continues to provide the structural demand floor, while export activity remains active but secondary during South America’s peak shipping window. With managed money now positioned net short rather than long, the market carries less liquidation risk but remains sensitive to shifts in global supply expectations. Unless South American production expectations change materially or U.S. export competitiveness improves, soybean price discovery is likely to remain anchored by steady domestic crush demand and the pace of Brazilian export flow.

Wheat Market Deep Dive

Futures & Spreads: Chicago SRW wheat futures edged higher during the week, with May settling near \$5.80 compared with roughly \$5.79 last Wednesday. The more meaningful development occurred in the nearby structure: the March–May spread flipped from carry into a modest inversion near four cents. That shift represents a notable change from the carry structure observed in recent weeks and indicates tightening nearby availability rather than an expansion of storage incentives. Volatility also moved higher relative to corn and soybeans, reflecting the market's sensitivity to shifting trade flows and speculative repositioning. While the flat price move itself was limited, the spread inversion signals that the front end of the curve has become more responsive to short-term supply and logistics dynamics.

Cash & Basis: Cash markets showed a firmer tone across export corridors. CIF Gulf SRW values are currently near +110H, indicating steady demand for nearby export slots despite limited improvement in global competitiveness. Plains HRW basis remains defensive near 40 cents under May futures, reflecting adequate regional coverage rather than aggressive commercial bidding. Pacific Northwest values were largely unchanged, with export programs continuing to operate at routine levels. Overall basis behavior suggests that the nearby inversion is being driven more by short-term positioning and logistics dynamics than by a widespread tightening in underlying physical supply.

Export Sales & Inspections: U.S. wheat export activity slowed somewhat during the latest reporting week. Export inspections for the week ending February 26 totaled roughly 0.34 MMT, below the prior week's pace but still leaving cumulative shipments near 18.62 MMT, roughly 19 percent ahead of last year. Export commitments now stand near 93 percent of USDA's marketing-year projection, meaning only modest additional sales are required to reach the forecast before the May marketing-year close. While the export program remains steady, shipment volumes alone are unlikely to materially tighten the U.S. balance sheet without an improvement in global competitiveness.

Global Context: International wheat pricing continues to be shaped by Black Sea supply. Russian 12.5 percent FOB offers are currently near \$234 per metric ton, maintaining a roughly \$29 per ton discount to comparable U.S. Gulf SRW values. That pricing advantage continues to anchor global trade flows into traditional import markets across North Africa and the Middle East. European wheat values have firmed modestly alongside the broader complex, but Black Sea origin remains the dominant pricing reference. As long as Russian exports continue moving without disruption, the global wheat market remains structurally well supplied despite short-term price fluctuations.

Funds & Positioning: Speculative positioning has shifted notably. Managed Money moved into a modest net long position near 17,700 contracts in Chicago SRW wheat following several weeks of short covering. The adjustment reflects the market's sensitivity to spread tightening and volatility rather than a wholesale shift in the global supply narrative. Even with the move into net long territory, speculative exposure remains relatively small compared with prior cycles. The current positioning suggests that funds have reduced downside conviction but have not yet established aggressive bullish exposure.

So What? Wheat's tone has improved modestly, but the broader balance sheet remains heavy. The shift of the March–May spread into inversion highlights tightening in the nearby structure and greater sensitivity to short-term positioning and logistics flows. At the same time, export competitiveness remains constrained by the persistent Black Sea pricing advantage, and global supply availability continues to limit sustained upside. With speculative positioning shifting away from outright shorts and volatility elevated relative to corn and soybeans, wheat may experience sharper short-term price swings. However, without a meaningful disruption to global export flows or a production shock in a major origin, the market remains fundamentally constrained by ample world supply.

US Cash Market & Basis

Corn: Corn basis held relatively firm across key export corridors even as futures edged higher during the week. CIF Gulf barge values remained near +85H, reflecting consistent export loading and active river movement. Interior river bids were roughly 20 cents under May futures, suggesting that elevators continue to source grain without needing to aggressively lift bids. Ethanol plants also maintained supportive bids as processors compete locally to secure supplies for steady grind rates. While basis has cooled slightly from the stronger levels seen earlier in the winter, export shipments and ethanol demand continue to provide the underlying support for the nearby cash market.

Soybeans: Soybean basis showed little directional change as global trade flows continue to rotate toward South American origin. CIF Gulf barge bids are currently near +90H, indicating ongoing export movement but below the stronger premiums observed earlier in the season. Interior processor bids around 40 cents under May futures suggest crushers have sufficient nearby coverage while maintaining strong run rates. With Brazilian exports ramping up rapidly during the harvest window, U.S. soybeans are moving into a more secondary role in international trade, leaving the domestic cash market stable but lacking strong upward pressure.

Wheat: Wheat cash markets leaned slightly firmer along export channels. CIF SRW basis near **+110H** reflects consistent vessel demand at the Gulf despite the persistent price advantage held by Black Sea suppliers. In the Plains, HRW basis remains near 40 cents under May futures, indicating comfortable regional supply levels and routine commercial activity. Pacific Northwest values were largely unchanged as export programs continue to operate at typical capacity. Basis strength at the Gulf therefore appears linked more to shipping schedules than to tightening inventories across the broader wheat market.

So What? Cash market signals across the grain complex continue to point toward active commercial movement rather than tightening availability. Corn basis remains comparatively supported by export flow and ethanol demand, soybeans are steady but constrained by Brazil's expanding export presence, and wheat basis reflects normal export scheduling despite intense global competition. Overall, basis behavior suggests that grain is moving through the system without difficulty, with demand channels operating steadily but not forcing a repricing of nearby supply.

International Cash & Trade Flows

Brazil: Brazil's soybean export pipeline is now shifting from harvest progress to shipment scale. ANEC projects March exports near 15.7 MMT, indicating that port logistics are moving into the highest loading period of the marketing year as freshly harvested supplies reach terminals. FOB Santos values around \$429/MT remain competitive relative to U.S. Gulf offers and continue to attract Asian demand during the seasonal export rotation. Corn exports remain minimal for now, with ANEC projecting roughly 0.47 MMT in March as exporters wait for the much larger safrinha crop later in the year. For the moment, Brazil's influence on global pricing is coming less from crop size and more from the speed at which soybeans are entering the export pipeline.

Argentina: Argentina's production outlook continues to carry uncertainty as crops move through late development stages. Current estimates place soybean production near 47.5 MMT and corn near 55 MMT, though crop conditions remain uneven following earlier heat stress. Recent rainfall has improved moisture levels in parts of the Pampas, but yield potential remains variable across regions. Export offers are present but relatively limited compared with Brazil's shipment volume, leaving Argentina's role in global markets tied more to potential supply revisions than to current trade flow.

China: Chinese import demand remains aligned with seasonal pricing incentives. Brazilian soybeans continue to hold a cost advantage over U.S. Gulf offers, leading Chinese buyers to concentrate forward purchases on South American origin during the harvest window. Dalian futures have traded within a relatively narrow range, reflecting stable feed demand and steady crushing margins rather than an expansion in consumption. Without new policy signals or large U.S. purchases, China's import program continues to rotate primarily through Brazil.

EU / Black Sea: Global wheat trade remains highly sensitive to price spreads between Black Sea origin and competing exporters. Russian 12.5% FOB wheat near \$234/MT maintains a sizeable discount to U.S. Gulf SRW values around \$263/MT, allowing Russia to retain a strong position in price-sensitive import markets. Ukrainian corn around \$232.50/MT also remains competitive into Mediterranean destinations. European wheat futures have firmed modestly alongside the broader complex, but global supply availability remains ample as long as Black Sea shipments continue moving without disruption.

Other Regions: Secondary exporters continue to supply grain through established trade routes. Australian wheat shipments remain active into Southeast Asia following a solid harvest, while Canadian spring wheat exports continue at a steady pace into traditional markets. No significant policy changes or logistical disruptions have emerged across these regions, leaving the broader international trade environment stable.

So What? The current global trade pattern reflects seasonal logistics more than structural supply shifts. Brazil's soybean shipments are expanding rapidly as harvest moves through the system, while Argentina remains the key production uncertainty that could influence later-season balances. In wheat, price spreads between Black Sea origin and other exporters continue to determine competitiveness across import markets. For now, global grain flows remain fluid and well supplied, with pricing differences rather than supply shortages directing trade.

Key Fundamentals & Reports (Feb 26 – Mar 04)

Export Inspections (USDA FGIS – week ending Feb 26): Inspection volume stayed active but the leadership remains clearly corn-led. Corn inspections totaled 1.86 MMT, pushing cumulative shipments to roughly 39.6 MMT and keeping the program about 45 percent ahead of last year's pace. Soybean inspections improved to 1.14 MMT, a healthier weekly print, but cumulative shipments near 26.2 MMT remain roughly 30 percent behind last year as trade continues to rotate through Brazil. Wheat inspections slowed to 0.34 MMT, leaving cumulative shipments around 18.6 MMT, still modestly ahead of last season but not at a pace that materially tightens the domestic outlook. Net-net, the complex continues to trade three different demand profiles: corn executing, soybeans functional but seasonally displaced, and wheat dependent on price spread competitiveness.

Export Sales (USDA FAS – latest through week ending Feb 19): Forward commitments continue to provide a useful gauge of export demand through the remainder of the marketing year. Corn export commitments now total roughly 62.96 MMT, representing about 75 percent of USDA's 83.83 MMT export projection. With roughly 20.9 MMT still required over the remaining 26 weeks, the implied shipment pace is near 0.80 MMT per week, well below the current four-week shipment average near 1.54 MMT, suggesting corn exports remain comfortably ahead of schedule. Soybean commitments stand around 35.65 MMT, equivalent to 83 percent of USDA's export forecast, leaving a relatively modest shipment requirement for the balance of the marketing year. Wheat commitments have reached approximately 93 percent of USDA's projection, meaning the export program is largely sold but dependent on steady shipment execution through the marketing year close. Overall, forward sales remain adequate across the complex, though the composition of demand continues to favor corn.

Ethanol Production & Stocks: Ethanol production eased slightly during the latest reporting week. Output declined to 1.095 million barrels per day, down roughly 18,000 barrels per day from the previous week. Ethanol inventories increased to approximately 26.34 million barrels (from 25.40 million), reflecting steady output alongside demand that remains stable but not accelerating. Margin proxies for Midwest plants remain positive but compressed near \$0.18 per gallon, largely due to firm cash corn premiums. The ethanol sector continues to provide consistent demand for corn, though the build in inventories suggests the industry is operating at a steady equilibrium rather than expanding grind rates further.

South American Production Updates: South American supply remains the dominant global variable. Brazil's CONAB raised its soybean production estimate to 177.98 MMT, confirming another record crop as harvest advances across the main producing regions. Corn production was revised slightly lower to 138.44 MMT, reflecting localized adjustments in early crop performance ahead of the safrinha cycle. In Argentina, soybean production estimates remain near 47.5 MMT, while corn production is projected around 55 MMT, though crop condition ratings remain historically weak following periods of heat stress earlier in the season. While Brazil's record crop continues to expand global supply availability, Argentina remains the key weather-sensitive variable capable of introducing volatility later in the season.

NOPA Soybean Crush: January U.S. soybean crush totaled 221.56 million bushels, beating expectations near 218.5 million and confirming that processors continue to run at high utilization rates. Strong soybean meal demand is sustaining crush margins even as soybean oil inventories remain comfortable, limiting the contribution from the energy side of the complex. The result is a domestic processing sector that continues to absorb U.S. soybeans steadily, providing balance sheet support while global export demand shifts toward Brazil during the peak harvest shipping window.

CFTC Positioning (as of February 24, released February 28): Speculative positioning shifted notably across the grain complex. Managed Money expanded its net short in corn to roughly 286,685 contracts, reflecting continued skepticism toward sustained rallies despite strong export execution. In soybeans, funds also moved into a deeper net short position near 171,392 contracts, reversing earlier constructive positioning and highlighting the market's adjustment to Brazil's harvest-driven export window. Wheat positioning moved in the opposite direction, with funds shifting to a modest net long near 17,758 contracts after several weeks of short covering. The repositioning suggests that speculative flows are becoming increasingly differentiated across the complex rather than uniformly defensive.

So What? Fundamental signals across the grain complex are becoming increasingly uneven. Corn continues to lead on export execution, with shipment pace comfortably exceeding the level required to meet USDA's forecast. Soybeans remain supported by steady inspections but continue to operate under the shadow of Brazil's expanding export flow. Wheat fundamentals remain comparatively neutral, with adequate export coverage but persistent global competition. Speculative positioning is also diverging across crops, with funds heavily short corn and soybeans while shifting toward a modest long in wheat. The result is a market structure where demand performance supports corn, seasonal supply caps soybeans, and wheat remains primarily influenced by global pricing dynamics rather than domestic fundamentals.

International Reports

Brazil: Brazil is shifting from harvest progress to export logistics as the central driver of market attention. Soybean harvest continues advancing across key producing regions, and the immediate focus has moved to the speed at which new-crop supplies are reaching export channels. ANEC projects March soybean exports near 15.7 MMT, indicating that port systems are entering their peak loading window. FOB Santos values around \$429/MT remain competitive into Asian destinations and continue to anchor global soybean price discovery during the current shipping cycle. Corn shipments remain limited for now,

with ANEC projecting roughly 0.47 MMT in March as exporters await the larger safrinha crop later in the year. While domestic pricing and currency dynamics continue to influence farmer selling, Brazil's primary influence on global markets at this stage lies in the scale and pace of soybean exports entering international trade.

Argentina: Argentina continues to represent the primary source of uncertainty within the South American supply outlook. Current estimates place soybean production near 47.5 MMT and corn near 55 MMT, but crop conditions remain fragile after earlier heat and moisture stress. Recent rainfall provided some localized improvement, yet yield potential varies widely across producing regions as crops move through late developmental stages. Export flows remain modest relative to Brazil's scale, meaning Argentina's influence on global markets is driven less by current shipments and more by the potential for further production adjustments. If additional weather stress develops during the final stages of the growing season, the country's supply outlook could still introduce volatility into global corn and soybean balances.

China: China's import behavior continues to align with seasonal price signals rather than aggressive inventory accumulation. Brazilian soybeans maintain a clear pricing advantage during the harvest window, keeping South American origin at the center of China's procurement strategy. U.S. shipments remain present but largely opportunistic within the current trade rotation. Domestic futures markets in Dalian have moved within a relatively narrow range, reflecting stable feed demand and steady crushing activity rather than a significant expansion in margins. No new policy measures or reserve interventions were announced during the reporting period, reinforcing the view that Chinese demand remains steady but tactical in its purchasing approach.

EU / Black Sea: Global wheat pricing continues to revolve around Black Sea export offers. Russian 12.5% protein wheat is currently quoted near \$234/MT FOB, maintaining a significant discount to U.S. Gulf values and preserving Russia's competitiveness in price-sensitive import markets. Ukrainian grain exports remain active through established shipping channels, and no disruptions to regional logistics have emerged. European wheat futures have firmed modestly alongside broader commodity markets, but the region's export pace still trails last year's level. As long as Black Sea supplies continue moving freely into global trade channels, the international wheat market remains anchored by abundant availability rather than supply constraint.

So What? Global trade is still being dictated by export price spreads and logistics timing, not by a supply shock. Brazil's March soybean lineup is now the dominant flow story as harvest volume reaches ports, while Argentina remains the swing variable mainly through potential production revisions rather than current shipment scale. In wheat, Black Sea offers continue to set the reference price into major import markets, keeping alternative exporters reactive. Until either South American weather forces a material estimate change or logistics bottlenecks become disruptive, international markets are likely to stay "competitive and well supplied" rather than structurally tight.

Weather & Crop Conditions

United States

U.S. crop weather remains largely uneventful as the market moves through the late-winter transition period. Winter wheat across the Plains continues under adequate snow cover and soil moisture conditions, limiting near-term freeze concerns. Forecast models point to a warmer pattern across much of the central U.S., which should help river logistics and freight movement normalize after earlier winter disruptions. With spring fieldwork still several weeks away and crops largely dormant, weather developments remain more relevant for transportation and monitoring potential winterkill than for immediate production expectations.

Brazil

Brazil's supply outlook remains historically large as harvest activity accelerates across the main producing regions. CONAB's latest estimate places soybean production near 177.98 MMT, confirming another record crop as harvesting progresses through central Brazil. Total corn production is projected near 138.44 MMT, with most expected output tied to the upcoming safrinha crop cycle. With harvest now well underway, market focus is gradually shifting from production estimates toward the pace at which newly harvested soybeans are moving through domestic logistics and into export channels.

Argentina

Argentina's production outlook remains stable but continues to carry elevated agronomic risk. Current estimates place soybean output near 47.5 MMT and corn production near 55 MMT, though crop condition ratings remain relatively weak following earlier periods of heat and dryness. Recent rainfall has provided partial relief in some Pampas regions, yet uneven moisture distribution continues to generate yield variability. As crops approach the final stages of development, the country remains a key weather-sensitive component of the global corn and soybean outlook.

China

China's domestic grain environment appears steady, with no major shifts in policy or reserve management reported during the week. Feed demand and crushing activity remain broadly stable, while Dalian futures have traded within a relatively narrow range. Import activity continues to favor Brazilian soybeans during the current harvest window, reflecting both price competitiveness and seasonal supply availability rather than a change in underlying demand.

EU / Black Sea

Weather conditions across Europe and the Black Sea region remain broadly stable as winter crops move through dormancy. No significant winterkill concerns have been reported in Russia, Ukraine, or the European Union, and export logistics from Black Sea ports continue to operate normally. With Russian wheat still priced competitively in global markets, the region continues to play a central role in setting international wheat benchmarks.

So What?

Weather conditions across major producing regions currently present few immediate supply threats. Brazil's harvest continues to expand global soybean availability, Argentina remains the primary source of potential late-season weather risk, and Northern Hemisphere crops are still early enough in the seasonal cycle that weather developments remain largely observational. For now, grain markets appear more responsive to export flows and logistics dynamics than to weather-driven production risks.

Synthesis & Outlook

This week's tape was driven less by the closes and more by what the forward curve signaled about near-term comfort. Corn and soybeans pushed higher on the board while wheat was mostly unchanged, but structure moved in three distinct directions. Corn remains in a clean carry with the March–May spread near 12 cents, consistent with storage economics staying intact and nearby coverage remaining comfortable. Soybeans tightened as the March–May carry compressed toward 10 cents, implying the market is absorbing harvest pressure rather than expanding incentives to store more. Wheat was the outlier, with the front end flipping to a modest inversion that looks more like a positioning/logistics squeeze than a sudden change in the global supply picture.

Corn remains the demand leader of the complex. Export inspections near **1.86 MMT** keep the U.S. shipment program running well ahead of last year, and cumulative exports now sit roughly **45 percent above the prior season's pace**. Gulf basis around **+85H** and steady ethanol grind reinforce the idea that the physical pipeline continues to move grain efficiently. What makes the setup unusual is speculative positioning: managed money remains heavily net short, holding nearly **287,000 contracts** against a

market that continues to execute on the demand side. The result is a corn market where the balance sheet remains comfortable, but the flow of grain through the system is strong enough to prevent meaningful downside momentum.

Soybeans are balancing a steady domestic floor against a global export window that still runs through Brazil. U.S. inspections improved week over week, but cumulative shipments remain materially behind last year as South American origin dominates nearby coverage. At the same time, crush demand continues to do its job underneath the board, and the tighter March–May carry suggests the market is no longer widening storage incentives just to clear Brazilian flow. The key point is timing: ANEC's roughly 15.7 MMT March shipment projection means the "Brazil supply wave" is shifting from expectation to physical pipeline reality, keeping rallies hard to sustain even as domestic disappearance helps prevent a deeper break.

Wheat remains the most structurally capped leg despite the front-end signal. The March–May inversion reflects a tighter nearby setup, but global price leadership still sits in the Black Sea. Russian 12.5 percent FOB near \$234/MT continues to undercut U.S. Gulf values by a meaningful margin, so the export story remains "steady but not transformative." Inspections slowed on the week, and while funds have shifted into a modest net long after covering, sustaining upside still requires the international spread to narrow or a disruption that forces importers away from Black Sea origin.

Weather remains the only meaningful wild card in an otherwise well-supplied system. Brazil's harvest is advancing rapidly and export infrastructure is beginning to absorb the flow of newly harvested soybeans. U.S. conditions remain quiet ahead of the spring planting season. Argentina continues to sit in the middle, with production estimates near **47.5 MMT for soybeans and 55 MMT for corn**, but crop conditions remain fragile following earlier heat stress. The market is watching Argentina closely, yet for now it remains a potential risk rather than a realized production shock.

Bullish triggers: Bullish catalysts would likely require confirmation that Argentine yield losses become large enough to tighten global balance sheets, or that Brazil's export logistics struggle to move the full volume of its crop during peak shipment months. Continued strength in U.S. corn exports could also tighten the domestic outlook if shipment pace remains well above the level required to meet USDA's forecast.

Bearish triggers: On the downside, a smooth Brazilian harvest and export campaign would reinforce South America as the seasonal pricing ceiling for soybeans and keep U.S. exports in a secondary role. Stabilization in Argentine weather would remove the primary risk premium currently embedded in the market. In wheat, the persistence of cheap Black Sea supply would continue to cap rallies unless geopolitical or logistical disruptions intervene.

In summary: Taken together, the week points to a market adjusting internally even as the broader supply picture remains intact. Corn continues to move grain efficiently through the export channel, and that steady flow is quietly supporting the balance sheet despite heavy speculative short exposure. Soybeans are entering the phase where Brazil's crop is no longer just an estimate but a logistical reality, and the tightening of nearby spreads suggests the market is beginning to absorb that volume rather than pushing it deeper into storage. Wheat is showing signs of short-term sensitivity through the nearby inversion, yet global trade remains anchored by competitively priced Black Sea supply. The result is not a decisive directional trend but a market increasingly influenced by structure, logistics, and positioning. Until a clearer disruption emerges, whether through weather, export competition, or policy, the grain complex is likely to remain driven by these incremental shifts rather than a single dominant catalyst.

Ethanol for America Act

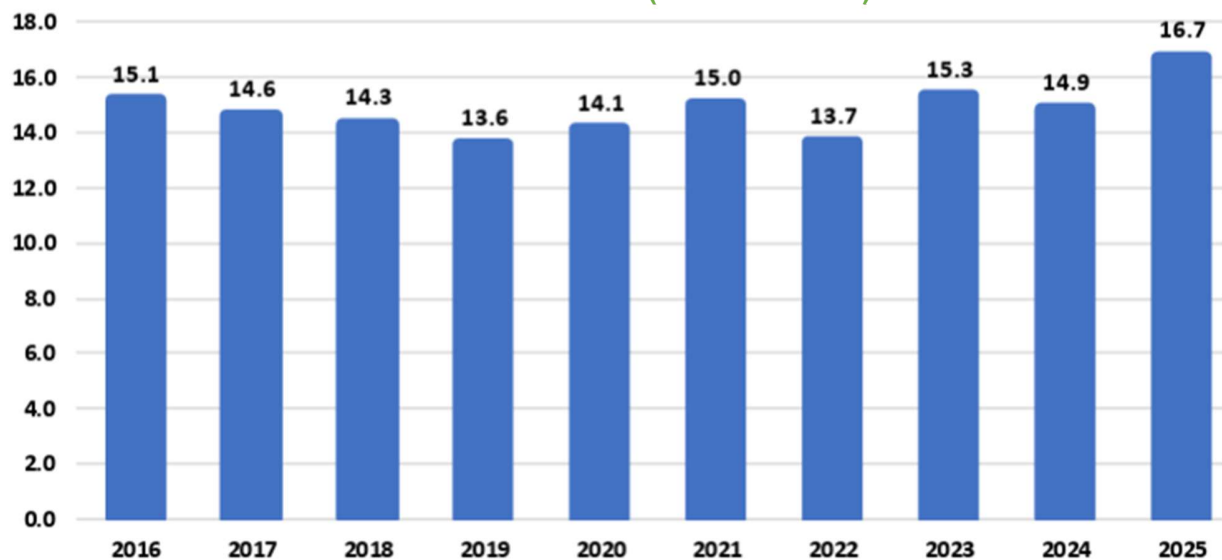
The major barrier to a higher Renewable Fuel Standard (RFS) is the fuel versus food debate. Now is the perfect time to move to E15. Corn prices are extremely low, and the latest USDA WASDE reported a record crop and a record crop expansion.

USDA WASDE forecast corn production at 16.7 billion bushels, with the yield at 188.8 bushels per acre and ending stocks at 2.1 billion. The season-average corn price dropped 30 cents to \$3.90 a bushel. Most importantly, 2025/26 crop year is expected to have 1.8 billion more bushels than 2024/25.

With current ethanol production consuming 5.6 billion bushels, a 10 percent increase in consumption would consume an additional 560 million bushels. The reality is that year around E15 would add approximately 50 million bushels and regulatory streamlining would add another 50 million bushels. At some point over the next ten years, the additional corn consumption could be 2.8 billion bushels minus lower fuel consumption resulting from electric vehicles. The ethanol corn consumption increase is likely to be more of a S curve as new compacity comes online.

With Brazil and the US corn and soybean production increasing, 100 million bushels of ethanol corn consumption will barely move the needle. The ethanol production capacity expansion that would be three to four years from now is when the corn consumption impact to the corn market would be felt.

US Corn Production (Billion Bushels)



Source: USDA

For example:

The National Corn Growers Association (NCGA) is intensifying its call for action from Congress and the administration after the US Department of Agriculture's latest World Agriculture and Supply and Demand Estimates report projected a record 16.7-billion-buShel corn crop this year, further threatening the livelihood of farmers already facing record-low corn prices.

"Corn growers are already marketing their corn for extremely low corn prices, and this massive projected corn supply without market-based solutions to increasing corn demand is already causing corn prices to fall further," said Illinois farmer and NCGA President Kenneth Hartman Jr. "Because we need markets fast for this supply, we are redoubling and intensifying our call for Congress to pass pending E15 legislation that will allow for year-round consumer access to higher blends of ethanol and for the Trump administration to quickly broker deals that will open new foreign markets for corn."

Today's WASDE report projects average corn yields of 188.8 bUShels per acre for 2025, for an overall crop of 16.7 billion bUShels. If the projections prove accurate, this year's crop will be the largest on record by far: 1.4 billion bUShels above the current production record set in 2023, a 9.1 percent increase.

An immediate boost to demand would be the passage of legislation authorizing year-round consumer access to 15 percent ethanol blend, or E15. This solution comes at no cost to consumers, requires no additional infrastructure developments and would generate demand for an additional 457 million bUShels of corn, according to NCGA estimates.

NCGA is also pUShing the administration to quickly broker additional deals with other countries and finalize details on deals already announced. For example, India, Vietnam and Kenya are all strategically important markets to US corn growers.

Sen. Joni Ernst, R-Iowa, on July 31 introduced the Ethanol for America Act, a bill that aims to make it easier for Americans to fuel their vehicles with domestically produced E15. Companion legislation was introduced the following day by Rep. Adrian Smith, R-Neb.

The legislation would eliminate unnecessary barriers to E15 by requiring the US EPA to finalize rulemaking from 2021 to make the E15 fuel label clearer and more consumer oriented. It would also confirm the compatibility of E15 with existing underground fuel storage and dispensing equipment.

Currently, fuel dispensers offering E15 must feature a label designed to alert customers to the appropriate and lawful use of the fuel. The proposed rule, issued in January 2021, co-proposes to either modify the E15 label or remove the label requirement entirely. The EPA opened a 90-day public comment period on the proposal but has failed to take final action on the rulemaking.

Following its introduction, the Senate bill, S. 2591, was referred to by the Senate Committee on Environment and Public Works. To date, Sens. Amy Klobuchar, D-Minn.; Deb Fischer, R-Neb.; Chuck Grassley, R-Iowa; Tammy Duckworth, D-Ill.; and Richard Durbin, D-Ill., have signed on to cosponsor the bill. The House bill, H.R. 4864, was referred to the House Committee on Energy and Commerce. Reps. Nikki Budzinski, D-Ill.; Dusty Johnson, R-S.D.; Tracey Mann, R-Kan.; Derek Schmidt, R-Kan.; Mike Flood, R-Neb.; Randy Feenstra, R-Iowa; and Brad Finstad, R-Minn., are cosponsoring the House bill.

Vietnam Opening Market to Ethanol

To boost ethanol imports from the US tenfold to approximately 290 million gallons, the Vietnam Biofuel Association has proposed that the government swiftly implement a nationwide E10 biofuel gasoline program.

The Vietnam Biofuel Association recently submitted a document to the Domestic Market Management and Development Department (under the Ministry of Industry and Trade), addressing several issues related to the import tax on 99 percent ethanol used for biofuel blending, as well as the broader context of tariff negotiations and trade relations between Vietnam and the United States.

According to the association, the import tax on 99 percent ethanol - a type specifically used in biofuel gasoline blending - has continuously decreased from 15 percent to 12 percent, then 10 percent, and most recently to 5 percent. These reductions fall within the broader trade policy framework between Vietnam and the US

Petrolimex and PVOIL, Vietnam's two largest fuel distributors and retailers, launched the country's first commercial trials of gasoline blended with 10 percent ethanol (E10) in three major cities last week. A total of 42 fuel stations in Hanoi, Ho Chi Minh City and Hai Phong began selling E10 RON95 gasoline as part of the trial that follows the Government of Vietnam's recent announcement of a nationwide E10 mandate to begin in January.

“The US Grains & BioProducts Council (USGBC) and its members and partners commend Petrolimex, PVOIL and the Government of Vietnam for advancing the use of fuel ethanol in Vietnam as a means to reduce harmful emissions, bolster fuel security and further stimulate rural economies,” said Ryan LeGrand, USGBC President and CEO. “This month’s rollout of E10 gasoline at retail stations is a massive step toward decarbonizing Vietnam’s transportation sector and a new potential partner for the US ethanol industry and the American farmer.”

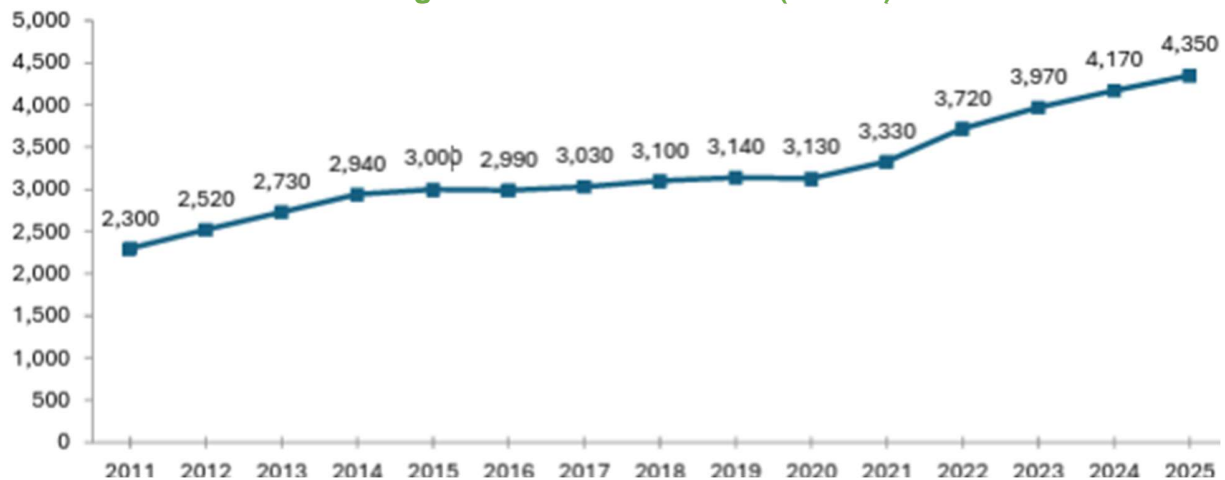
In 2018, Vietnam implemented an E5 mandate for its RON92 grade of gasoline, one of two gasoline grades widely used throughout the country. The Government of Vietnam’s decision to expand and migrate the country’s ethanol policy in 2026 to E10 and all grades of gasoline, including the more widely used RON95 grade, will help the Vietnamese fuel industry amplify the environmental and economic benefits of fuel ethanol use which augment Vietnam’s policy objectives.

Vietnam’s gasoline consumption surpassed 2.8 billion gallons in 2024, increasing 8.1 percent from 2023 consumption levels. A nationwide E10 mandate will create a total fuel ethanol demand of 280 to 300 million gallons per year, depending on gasoline demand.

USDA Land Value Report

The United States farm real estate value, a measurement of the value of all land and buildings on farms, averaged \$4,350 per acre for 2025, up \$180 per acre (4.3 percent) from 2024. The United States cropland value averaged \$5,830 per acre, an increase of \$260 per acre (4.7 percent) from the previous year. The United States pasture value averaged \$1,920 per acre, an increase of \$90 per acre (4.9 percent) from 2024.

Average Farm Real Estate Value (Dollars)



Source: USDA NASS

\$/Acre

- more than 8,400
- 5,101 - 8,400
- 3,201 - 5,100
- 2,201 - 3,200
- 2,200 or less

United States
4,350
4.3%

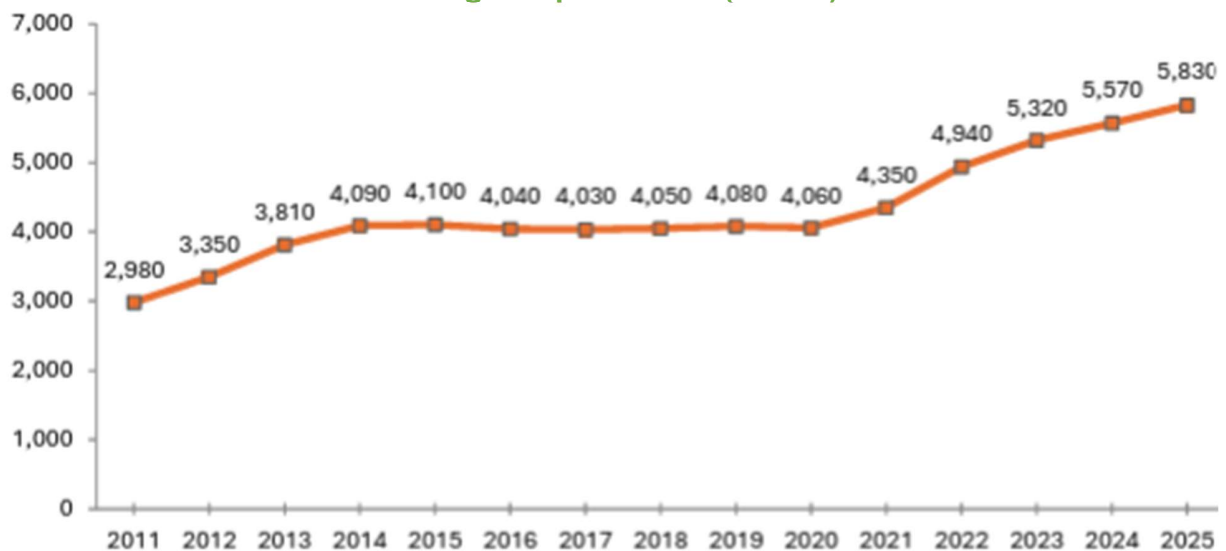
NP = Not Published due to insufficient reports

USDA - NASS August 1, 2025

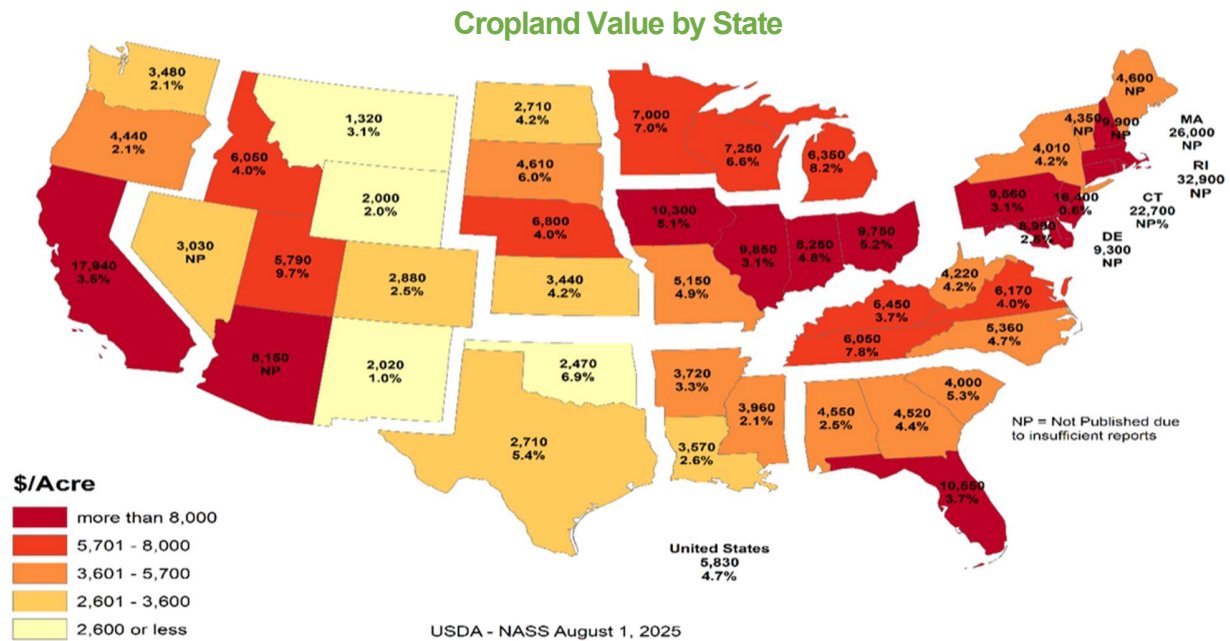
State	Value (\$/Acre)	% Change
Alabama	6,700	5.3%
Alaska	3,710	2.5%
Arizona	4,180	4.5%
Arkansas	3,100	4.4%
California	13,700	2.2%
Colorado	2,970	6.1%
Connecticut	14,400	0.7%
Delaware	9,500	NP
District of Columbia	1,200	4.3%
Florida	8,700	4.6%
Georgia	4,720	4.9%
Hawaii	3,850	3.5%
Idaho	2,230	2.5%
Illinois	8,930	2.6%
Indiana	8,850	4.0%
Iowa	9,790	3.9%
Kansas	2,360	4.4%
Kentucky	4,250	4.2%
Louisiana	5,480	3.4%
Maine	14,900	4.2%
Maryland	6,150	7.7%
Massachusetts	22,500	2.3%
Michigan	6,420	4.9%
Minnesota	6,800	7.8%
Mississippi	5,470	5.4%
Missouri	3,520	2.9%
Montana	1,000	2.6%
Nebraska	2,280	4.1%
Nevada	1,200	4.3%
New Hampshire	6,500	4.0%
New Jersey	16,600	2.5%
New Mexico	2,540	5.8%
New York	8,490	4.0%
North Carolina	6,100	4.3%
North Dakota	2,970	6.8%
Ohio	9,350	6.7%
Oklahoma	3,200	4.2%
Oregon	3,780	1.6%
Pennsylvania	8,750	3.0%
Rhode Island	22,500	2.3%
South Carolina	5,470	5.4%
South Dakota	2,230	2.5%
Tennessee	4,250	4.2%
Texas	2,970	6.1%
Utah	2,230	2.5%
Vermont	4,400	1.1%
Virginia	6,150	7.7%
Washington	3,710	2.5%
West Virginia	4,250	4.2%
Wisconsin	6,420	4.9%
Wyoming	2,230	2.5%

USDA - NASS August 1, 2025

Average Cropland Value (Dollars)

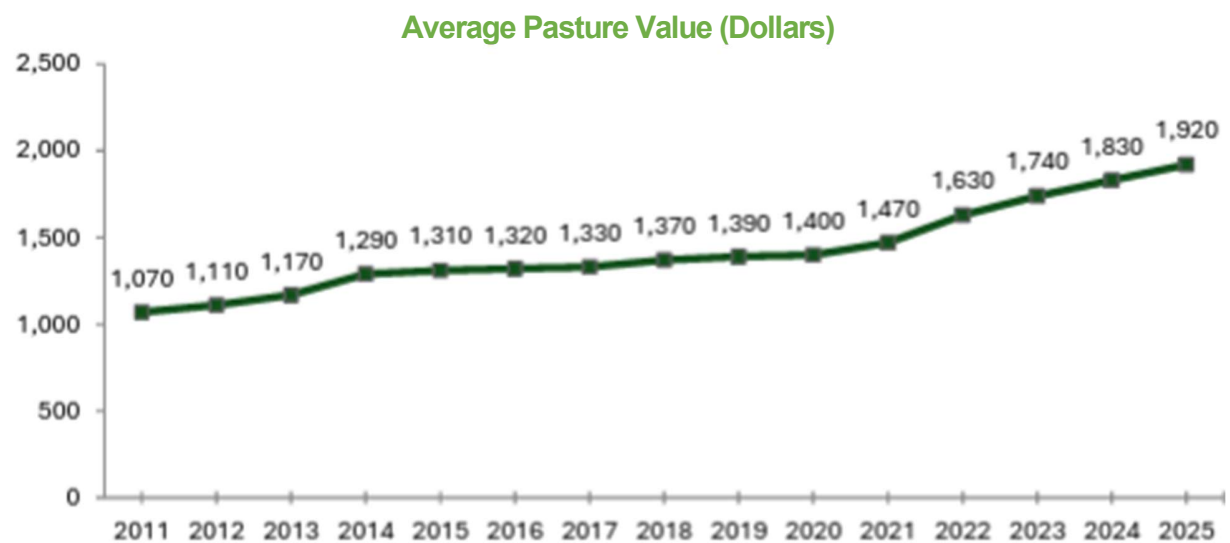


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US pastureland values continued their upward trend in 2025, rising to \$1,920 per acre, a 5 percent increase over 2024. This growth is nearly in line with last year's 5.2 percent gain but remains below the 6.7 percent increase in 2023 and the sharp 11 percent jump in 2022, which followed nearly a decade of stagnant values.

Unlike cropland and overall farm real estate, pastureland values are highest along the East Coast and mid-South, where development pressures, land scarcity and lifestyle demand contribute to elevated prices. In contrast, Western and Plains states report lower average values, partly due to lower land productivity and the prevalence of federally owned grazeable land accessed through grazing permits, which reduces market-based competition. In densely populated Eastern states, fragmentation of land and rising competition for open space (whether for grazing, recreation or rural living) continue to drive up per-acre costs for the limited private pastureland available.



Source: USDA NASS



NASS also released data on cash rents, which tend to lag changes in land values and commodity prices due to early-season lease negotiations. While the reported figures reflect past agreements, they often serve as important benchmarks for future producer-landlord negotiations, especially in areas with variable rent structures. Average US cropland rent increased to \$161 per acre in 2025, a modest 0.6 percent rise over 2024, just \$1 per acre. Irrigated cropland rents declined by 0.4 percent to \$244 per acre, while non-irrigated rents rose 0.7 percent to \$147 per acre. Pastureland cash rents remained unchanged at \$15.50 per acre.

While earlier rent increases were tied closely to the 2021–2022 commodity price boom, today's changes are more uneven, shaped by regional water constraints and shifting cropping patterns. In some areas, recent federal disaster assistance may have tempered pressure to renegotiate downward, even as commodity prices weaken and input costs remain high.

U.S. AVERAGE +0.6%

**MA: -6%
NJ: -1%
DE: 3%
MD: -3%**

State	Percentage Change (1990-2000)
Alaska	0.0%
Arizona	-2.6%
Arkansas	0.6%
California	3.3%
Colorado	2.4%
Connecticut	0.0%
Delaware	3%
District of Columbia	-3%
Florida	2.2%
Georgia	0.0%
Hawaii	-10%
Idaho	8.2%
Illinois	-1.9%
Indiana	-1.7%
Iowa	3.8%
Kansas	1.3%
Kentucky	-2.3%
Louisiana	6.7%
Maine	0.0%
Maryland	-3%
Massachusetts	-6%
Michigan	-0.7%
Minnesota	0.0%
Mississippi	4.9%
Missouri	-0.7%
Montana	1.8%
Nebraska	0.8%
Nevada	-0.6%
New Hampshire	0.0%
New Jersey	-1%
New Mexico	-7.4%
New York	1.9%
North Carolina	5.0%
North Dakota	0.0%
Ohio	4.2%
Oklahoma	5.3%
Oregon	10.7%
Pennsylvania	-0.5%
Rhode Island	0.0%
South Carolina	4.7%
South Dakota	0.0%
Tennessee	-2.5%
Texas	6.5%
Vermont	0.0%
Virginia	0.0%
Washington	0.0%
West Virginia	-5.3%
Wisconsin	2.5%
Wyoming	0.0%

Washington and Montana led the country in cropland cash rent growth, up 10.7 percent and 8.2 percent, respectively, followed by Alabama at 8.1 percent. Meanwhile, cropland rents in Hawaii, New Mexico, Wyoming, West Virginia and Massachusetts declined by more than 5 percent, likely due to a mix of stabilized drought conditions, changing land use priorities and rebalancing after years of sharp growth.

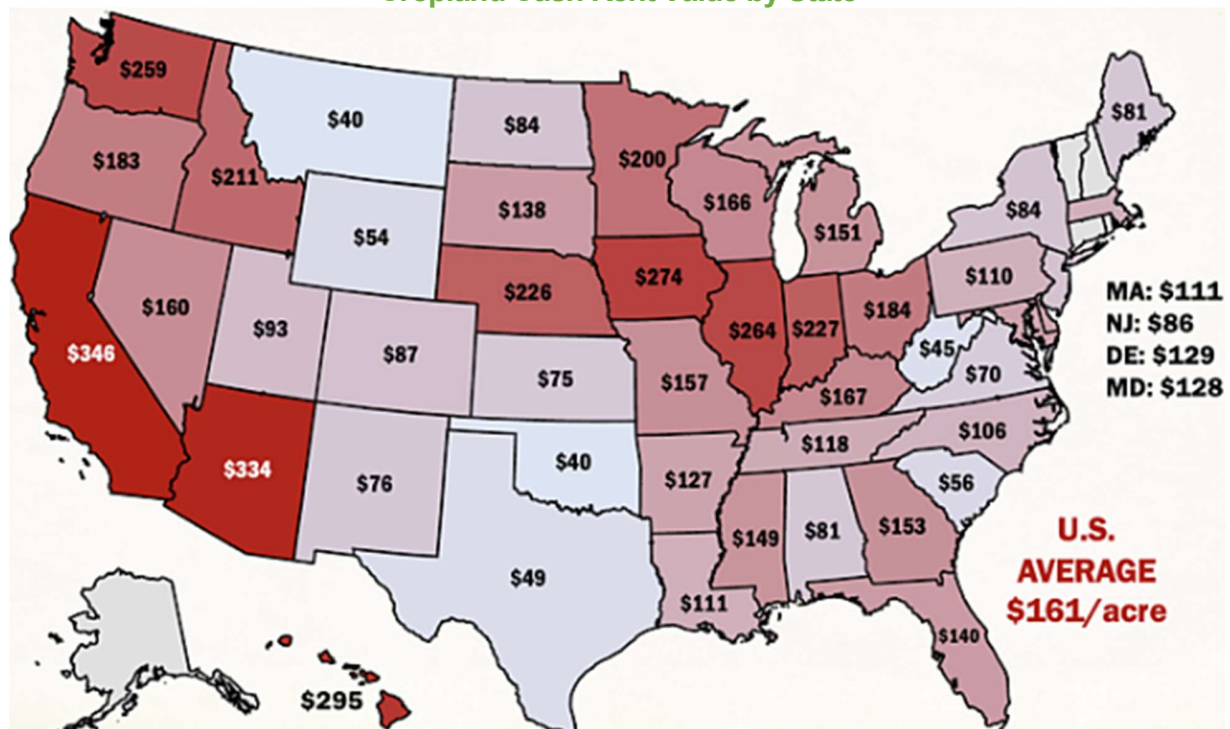
Margins for producers who rely heavily on rented land remain precarious, especially as revenue potentially slips while fixed costs (including rents) remain elevated or inflexible. Beginning farmers and those without land equity are especially exposed, facing steep barriers to accessing operating credit. In a year where net farm income is forecasted to decline without ad hoc support, even modest increases in rental rates can have outsized financial consequences.

Rural land values are experiencing a price bubble. In many of the Corn Belt states the cropland value continues to increase while the cash rent decreases. The values represent the impact of government land-based farm programs and ad hoc payment that could go to landowners. The government incentives to buy land have diminished the link between land values and real agricultural value. The result is farmers who rent land are increasingly in financial distress. As farmers exit the market, the disconnect between the land prices and cash rents will increase.

What the government gives it can take away. The Democrat party can win without the farm vote. Their messaging is trending away from “preserving family farmers” to “bashing Big Ag.” If rural land prices start declining, the floor is real agricultural value. For example, Illinois cash rent for cropland is \$264 per acre. Farmdoc crop budget indicates that if a cash rent farmer needs \$100 profit per acre to survive, the cash rent should be approximately \$133 per acre or a decrease of approximately half. Assuming a 5 percent rate of return, the real agricultural value for cropland in Illinois is \$2,660 per acre versus \$9,850 per acre.

The other concern is that many of the new land buyers are investors. The investors are helping to drive land prices higher. When land values decrease, will the investors sit tight or take a profit? The investors do not have the same emotional attachment to the land. Farmers who want to own their own land act as a “put” under the land market. The good news is the farmers currently have low debt levels. This means the farmers have access to cash to buy land. The unknown is if the farmers are making a good investment or trying to catch a falling knife.

Cropland Cash Rent Value by State

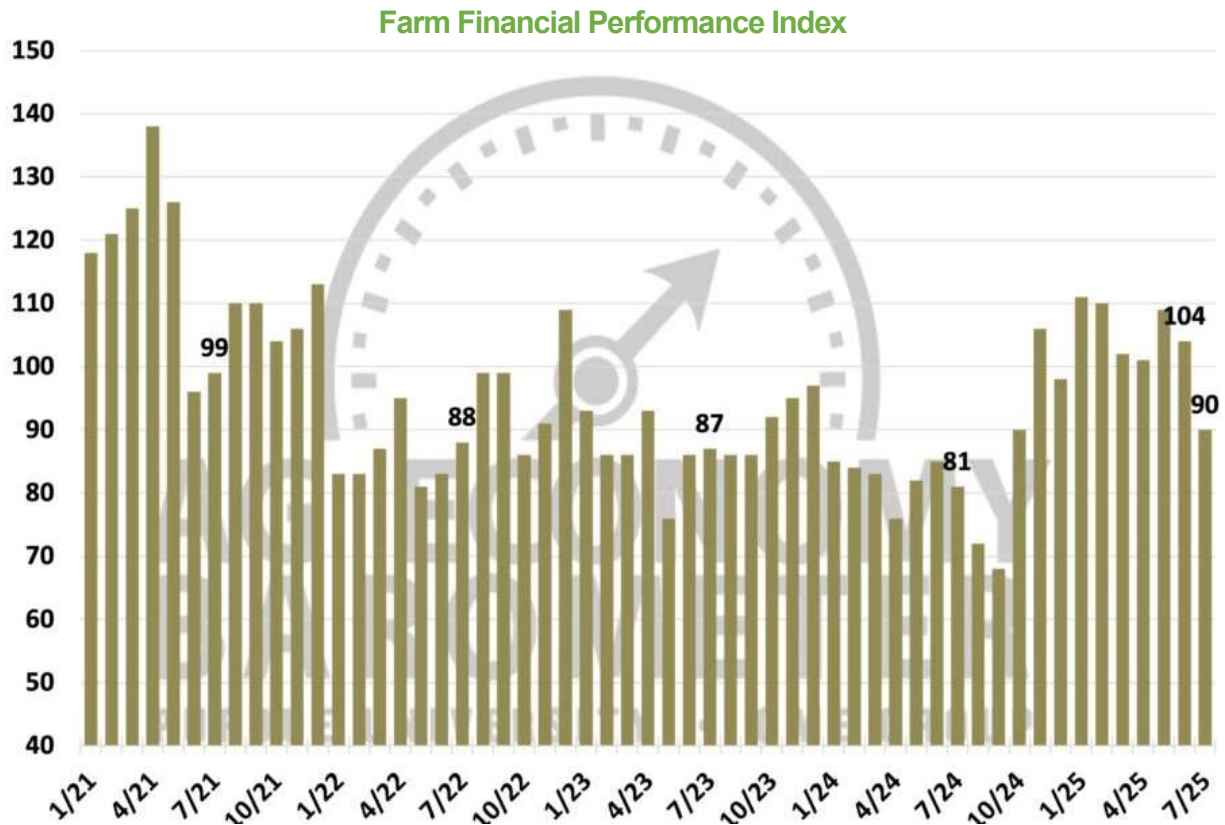


Source: American Farm Bureau, USDA NASS

Farmer Sediment

The Purdue University-CME Group Ag Economy Barometer index declined for the second month in a row. The July index fell 11 points below June's reading and was fueled by US farmers' weaker perceptions regarding both current conditions and their expectations for the future. The July Current Conditions Index fell 17 points while the Future Expectations Index declined 7 points, both compared to a month earlier. Weaker income prospects in 2025 were largely responsible for farmers' weaker appraisal of current conditions. Although all three principal farmer sentiment indices were lower in July than a month earlier, producer sentiment remains much more positive than at this time last year, with nearly three-quarters of July's survey respondents reporting that the US is headed “in the right direction.” The July barometer survey took place from July 7-11, 2025.

Concerns about weak income prospects in 2025 were evident in the July survey as the Farm Financial Performance Index fell 14 points compared to a month earlier. This month's decline left the index at a reading of 90, indicating that more farmers expect weaker rather than stronger income in 2025 compared to 2024. Weakening crop prices are eroding income prospects. For example, in the Eastern Corn Belt, bids for fall harvest delivery of corn and soybeans were 7 percent and 3 percent lower during the July survey week, respectively, than just 4 weeks earlier. In turn, the decline in farmers' income prospects helped push the Farm Capital Investment Index down 7 points in July to a reading of 53.



Source: Purdue/CME Group Ag Economy Barometer

Unsurprisingly, a weaker income outlook led to a softer outlook for farmland values in the upcoming year. The Short-Term Farmland Value Expectations Index dipped 5 points below a month earlier. This month's reading of 115 also left the index 3 points lower than a year earlier and 10 points below two years ago. The farmland index's weakness was attributable to a small shift among respondents away from expecting values to rise to looking for weakening values in the upcoming year, while the percentage expecting values to hold steady rose just one point to 57 percent. With farmland leasing discussions for next year underway between farmers and landowners, this month's survey included a question regarding crop producers' expectations for farmland cash rental rates in 2026. Despite weakening crop income prospects, nearly three-fourths (73 percent) of respondents said they expect cash rental rates in 2026 to remain about the same, with just 11 percent of crop producers indicating they expect rental rates to decline.

One supporting factor for both farmland values and farmland cash rental rates could be producers' expectations regarding the farm income safety net provided by US farm programs. In this month's survey, 31 percent of respondents said they expect the safety net in the 2025 Farm Bill to be stronger than in the previous Farm Bill.

US farmers in July were somewhat more optimistic about future agricultural trade prospects than a month earlier. This month, 43 percent of respondents said they expect agricultural exports to increase in the upcoming five years, up from 41 percent a month earlier. Fewer producers said they are looking for exports to decline, dropping to 13 percent of respondents, down from 16 percent who felt that way in June. In a related question, 64 percent of this month's survey respondents said they think it likely that new foreign export markets will open to American agricultural goods in the next five years. To further gauge US farmers' outlook regarding trade and policy, this month's survey included the following question: "Would you say things in the United States today are generally headed in the right direction or on the wrong track?" Seventy-four percent of respondents said the US is headed in the "right direction."

US farmers' sentiment declined in July as weaker farm income prospects dimmed producers' view of current conditions and their future expectations. Despite a weaker crop income outlook, just 11 percent of crop producers said they expect farmland cash rental rates to decline, with a majority reporting that they expect rental rates to stay about the same. Helping to support producers' farmland value and rental rate outlook is farmers' expectation for a stronger farm income safety net, with nearly one-third (31 percent) of US producers saying they expect the 2025 Farm Bill to provide a stronger safety net than the previous Farm Bill. Producers in July were somewhat more optimistic about US agricultural trade prospects than in June, while nearly three-fourths (74 percent) of US farmers responding to the survey reported that they feel that things in the US are headed "in the right direction."

Bunge Buys IFF Crush Division

As part of its second quarter results disclosure, International Flavors & Fragrances Inc. announced that it has entered into a definitive agreement to divest its soybean crush, concentrates, and lecithin business to Bunge Global S.A. The transaction includes operations that generated approximately \$240 million in revenue in 2024 and employs around 250 people globally. The sale aligns with IFF's strategy to strengthen its portfolio and supports the ongoing evaluation of strategic alternatives for its Food Ingredients segment, with a focus on maximizing shareholder value.

Greenhouse Gas Phase 3 Standards do not Apply to Human Health

The industry has an aftertreatment system for EPA's 2007 and 2010 Heavy-Duty Highway Engines and Vehicle emissions reduction regulations, which set standards for not only NOx but also particulate matter (PM). It also mandated the use of advanced emission control technologies like selective catalytic reduction (SCR) and diesel particulate filters. "Completely separate," said North American Council for Freight Efficiency Executive Director Mike Roeth. "Aftertreatment is not a direct GHG solution. We tend to call NOx and PM pollutant emissions, and they are directly attached to human health; breathing in these in the air... Carbon/GHG is different in that it affects climate, encouraging our more frequent and harsher weather events causing other health concerns."

Daimler Truck North America (DTNA) noted in a statement to Commercial Carrier Journal (CCJ) that the proposal does not modify EPA's existing requirements for criteria pollutants, including NOx and PM. NOx and PM standards remain in place, and they continue to be enforced independently of any changes to GHG regulations. "Selective Catalytic Reduction (SCR) systems, Diesel Exhaust Fluid (DEF), and aftertreatment technologies are essential components designed to reduce nitrogen oxides (NOx) regulated under the EPA's Clean Air Act," added Paccar companies Kenworth and Peterbilt. "The current aftertreatment systems related to NOx are still required to meet EPA and CARB standards and are independent of greenhouse gas (GHG) specific mandates."

Covered in the Endangerment Finding is nitrous oxide (N₂O). NOx is shorthand for nitric oxide (NO) and nitrogen dioxide (NO₂), the nitrogen oxides most relevant for air pollution. NOx itself is not considered a greenhouse gas; rather it plays a role in the formation of ozone, a naturally occurring greenhouse gas.

Thus, NOx is not a greenhouse gas and the aftertreatment system, including DEF, would not be affected by this pending regulatory change.

However, EPA Administrator Lee Zeldin said in March his office intends to revisit portions of the Biden-era Clean Trucks Plan, which includes the 2022 Heavy-Duty NOx rule – a standard that includes new, more stringent emissions standards that cover a wider range of heavy-duty engine operating conditions and requires these more stringent emissions standards to be met for a longer period of time.

DEF Guidance Clarification

Starting in the early 2010s, regulations required all new on-road diesel vehicles, tractors, trucks, buses, ships, locomotives, gas turbines and construction equipment, to install additional technology to reduce nitrogen oxide emissions, a byproduct of diesel. Almost all commercial diesel transportation and equipment today has Selective Catalytic Reduction (SCR) technology that runs on DEF.

According to an EPA release, "EPA issued clear guidance urging engine and equipment manufacturers to revise DEF system software in existing vehicles and equipment to prevent these sudden shutdowns, giving operators more time to repair faults without impacting productivity or safety."

The EPA provided a chart showing derate timing for heavy duty trucks will be extended from a 5-mph limitation after just four hours' worth of a system fault to a three-stage derate:

- 15 percent torque reduction at 650 miles / 10 hours
- 30 percent torque reduction then at 4,200 miles / 80 hours
- and a final-stage derate to 25 mph at 8,400 miles / 160 hours

"In addition to providing certainty to manufacturers about how EPA wants this issue resolved, the agency is not requiring separate approvals beyond that provided in EPA's guidance," the release said. "This ensures that bureaucratic steps do not delay manufacturers' ability to put solutions into the field."

Before the new EPA DEF guidance, a farmer had four hours before the vehicle or equipment stopped operating, leaving the farmer stranded. EPA's new guidance to engine manufacturers will reduce derating, an automatic trigger forcing the engine to operate at a reduced capacity far below its capability and increase the amount of time operators must secure DEF and refuel.

Previously, farmers and truckers faced rapid engine slowdown to 5 mph within just four hours of a sensor alert. Under EPA's new guidance for heavy-duty trucks, for example, after a fault is detected, only a warning light appears for 650 miles or 10 hours. Most significantly, there is no performance impact for at least one workday. Then, the engine only mildly derates by 15 percent, but this does not limit speed, allowing trucks to operate normally for up to 4,200 miles or two work weeks. Only after about four work weeks does speed drop to 25 mph until repairs are made. Most operators are expected to fix issues well before reaching this limit. Moving forward for farmers, non-road equipment will not experience an impact for the first 36 hours.

The ruling represents a major step up from the status quo by giving operators significantly more time to address faults before experiencing severe engine or speed limitations, which will improve their ability to complete daily operations and reduce downtime.

The revised DEF guidance is estimated to reduce farming expenses by \$727 million annually. With fewer disruptions, reduced costs for emergency towing, repairs, rentals, DEF deliveries and inventories, producers will have greater operational and financial control.

Truck Manufacturers Sue CARB/California

Four of America's top truck makers have officially filed a lawsuit in the US District Court for the Eastern District of California challenging the Clean Truck Partnership (CTP) agreement signed with the California Air Resources Board in 2023. CARB has argued since the Congressional rollback of its Advanced Clean Trucks and Omnibus Low-NOx rules earlier this summer that despite the federal disapproval of the regulations, the CTP is still binding.

Cummins, Daimler Trucks North America, Hino, Isuzu, then-Navistar, Paccar, the Truck and Engine Manufacturers Association, and Volvo Group North America in July 2023 were among 11 signers of the CTP, an agreement with CARB that pledged truck and engine manufacturers will meet California's vehicle standards and required the sale and adoption of zero-emission vehicle (ZEV) technology.

The OEMs said in the lawsuit that despite the Congressional Review Acts passed this year preempting California's emissions standards, the state "continues to demand compliance with its heavy-duty emissions standards, and it has threatened OEMs that design, develop, manufacture and sell heavy-duty vehicles and engines ... with civil sanctions and unfavorable regulatory treatment if the OEMs refuse to comply with the state's unlawful standards, while also taking measures to insulate itself from lawful challenges to those standards."

Senior Clean Vehicles Advocate for the Natural Resources Defense Council Guillermo Ortiz called the lawsuit, "a cynical reversal of course. These companies helped negotiate the Clean Truck Partnership to secure regulatory certainty. Now they're trying to dismantle the very deal they shaped -- injecting instability into a market they claim to lead," he said. "This is bad faith, plain and simple, and it raises questions about whether these manufacturers are serious about their ability to deliver clean trucks to the global stage."

The OEMs said the US Department of Justice has sent them Cease & Desist letters stating that California's enforcement of its regulations "is contrary to federal law" and directed the truck makers "to immediately cease and desist compliance with California's preempted and unlawful mandates."

This has left the OEMs "caught in the crossfire," they said, as "California demands that OEMs follow preempted laws; the United States maintains such laws are illegal and orders OEMs to disregard them. This situation is not tenable."

As such, the lawsuit aims to clarify the OEMs' legal obligations under federal and state law and to block California from enforcing regulations that are preempted by federal law. Given the inconsistencies between federal and California regulatory requirements for emissions, truck and engine makers and their trade associations in 2023 petitioned CARB for relief from the state's "infeasible regulatory requirements," which resulted in the CTP, the lawsuit added. Now, according to the OEMs, "California seeks to use the Clean Truck Partnership, which was intended to harmonize compliance with state and federal law, to compel an entire industry to follow California emissions standards that are now in conflict with federal law, and which have been expressly preempted by federal law." They added that the state is disregarding the CTP's "plain language," which "states that manufacturers are obligated to follow CARB's emissions regulations 'regardless of the outcome of any litigation challenging ... those regulations, or CARB's overall authority to implement those regulations,' not federal legislative action taken to invalidate them."

The regulatory back-and-forth between the federal government and California/CARB has put OEMs "in an impossible position," they said in the lawsuit. "As a result, the OEMs are subject to two sovereigns whose regulatory requirements are irreconcilable and who are openly hostile to one another. Each wields a hammer to enforce its will on industry, leaving OEMs -- who simply seek to sell heavy-duty trucks in compliance with the law -- unable to plan with the necessary certainty and clarity where their products need to be certified for sale and by which regulatory authority."

California, citing the CTP, has contended that in order for OEMs to legally sell trucks in the state, they must obtain certification from CARB. Yet the OEMs said this process “takes months,” adding that they “need to know within a matter of weeks whether they must obtain a model year 2026 certification from CARB in order to lawfully sell their products in California and other opt-in states, which together represent approximately 25 percent of the national market for new vehicle registrations for heavy-duty vehicles.”

In filing the lawsuit, the truck makers said they are looking for “declaratory and injunctive relief with the goal of clarifying and establishing the regulatory obligations that they must follow to lawfully offer products for sale in California and the various opt-in states, and to prevent California officials from violating their constitutional rights,” adding that “an expeditious decision is essential.”

The OEMs’ lawsuit joins another suit brought by the Western States Trucking Association that challenged CARB’s authority to enforce the CTP following the federal preemption of the regulations.

Ambassador Jamieson Greer: Why We Remade the Global Order

The following op-ed provides the foreign policy vision of the Trump Administration. On the 200-day mark of the second Trump administration, United States Trade Representative Jamieson Greer published an op-ed in The New York Times explaining how President Trump’s trade policy is remaking the international economic order to reduce our trade deficit and deliver lasting benefits for American workers and industries.

The full text of the op-ed is below:

It mUST be an unwritten rule that international economic orders emerge at stately hotels. In 1944, as World War II raged, Allied representatives gathered at a picturesque New Hampshire resort named Bretton Woods to discUSs how to establish a postwar economic order to restore the sensible flow of trade in a fractured world.

Although the resulting Bretton Woods system ended in 1976, its legacy lives on. Our current, nameless global order, which is dominated by the World Trade Organization and is notionally designed to pursue economic efficiency and regulate the trade policies of its 166 member countries, is untenable and unsUSTainable. The United States has paid for the system with the loss of indUStrial jobs and economic security, other countries have been unable to make needed reforms, and the biggest winner has been China, with its state-owned enterprises and five-year plans. Unsurprisingly, the past decade has seen significant international and bipartisan American frUStration at the system’s failure to adapt to meet the essential interests of sovereign nations.

Now, reform is at hand. Last week at his Turnberry resort on the Scottish coast, President Trump and the European Commission president, Ursula von der Leyen, concluded a historic agreement , one that is fair, balanced and oriented toward serving concrete national interests rather than vague aspirations of multilateral institutions. Indeed, by USing a mix of tariffs and deals for foreign market access and investment, the United States has laid the foundation for a new global trading order.

The previoUS system rejected tariffs as a legitimate tool of public policy, meaning that the United States sacrificed tariff protection for critical manufacturing and other sectors. Over the past three decades, the United States slashed barriers to our market to allow vast inflows of foreign goods, services, labor and capital. At the same time, other countries kept their markets closed to our goods and deployed a suite of policies , such as subsidies, wage suppression, lax labor and environmental standards, regulatory distortions and currency manipulation , to artificially boost exports to the United States. This approach made the United States and a handful of other economies the consumers of last resort for countries pursuing beggar-thy-neighbor economic policies.

Our trading partners were adept at this game, and elites on Wall Street and in Washington were all too happy to cash in on the global arbitrage by moving production abroad. The net result? The bulk of global manufacturing shifted to jurisdictions such as China, Vietnam and Mexico where

companies could exploit vulnerable workers or benefit from expansive state support while the United States ran up what in absolute terms is the highest trade deficit in the history of the world. This led to extensive and well-documented losses in US industrial capacity and employment as well as reliance on our adversaries for critical supply chains.

We subordinated our country's economic and national security imperatives to a lowest common denominator of global consensus. This approach harmed American workers, their families and communities by undermining a manufacturing sector that creates high-wage jobs, fosters innovation and catalyzes investment across the economy.

What began at Bretton Woods as a necessary effort to rebuild a global trade system shattered by war evolved, over nine rounds of trade negotiations, into something unrecognizable. The measured guidelines for commerce developed in the Kennedy and Tokyo Rounds gave way to our recent experiment in global hyper-integration, embodied in the Uruguay Round, which concluded in 1994 and established the W.T.O.

We are now witnessing the Trump Round. On April 2, President Trump announced tariffs to address the national emergency posed by the trade deficit. The intense bilateral negotiations that followed were held in diverse locations across the world: Washington, Geneva, Jeju Island, Paris, London, Stockholm and, of course, Turnberry. Our trading partners had never before shown such interest in opening their markets to the United States, aligning on matters of economic and national security, and rebalancing trade in a more sustainable direction. In a few short months, the United States secured more foreign market access than it had in years of fruitless W.T.O. negotiations.

Reversing decades of harmful policy that weakened our manufacturing capacity and work force will take time and coordinated effort across the public and private sectors. But keeping the status quo would only accelerate the dangerous trajectory of deindustrialization. We require a generational project to re-industrialize America, and time is short.

When I joined a critical mass of my fellow trade ministers in June at a meeting of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development in Paris, I was struck by how many voiced serious concerns about the danger of macroeconomic imbalances, the threat of nonmarket practices and the sclerotic state of the global trading system, the same issues President Trump has raised for years and now taken emergency action to address. What was long dismissed as heresy by the free-trade fundamentalists in Brussels, Geneva and Washington is now becoming conventional wisdom.

In announcing the US-European Union deal last week, President von der Leyen echoed the call to refashion global trade to adapt to economic and political realities. She explained to reporters that the trans-Atlantic economic relationship needed "rebalancing" to ensure that it could be "more sustainable." Such recognition is reinforced by additional deals with Britain, Cambodia, Indonesia, Japan, Malaysia, Pakistan, the Philippines, South Korea, Thailand and Vietnam, which make up almost 40 percent of US trade, according to my office's figures. Other countries with large trade surpluses with the United States are subject to generally higher tariffs. The new economic order, solidified at Turnberry, is emerging in real time.

The results are astounding. Every year for 40 years, the Office of the US Trade Representative has produced a detailed report called the National Trade Estimate chronicling various barriers faced by US companies, including high tariffs, requirements to produce goods in the countries where the companies want to do business, and restrictions on agricultural products contrary to scientific consensus. In the past, the only significant way the United States could remove these barriers (if at all) was by giving away the tariffs defending our manufacturing sector. President Trump has flipped the script on this: Now, we are systematically eliminating these barriers abroad while ensuring sufficient tariff protection at home.

Indonesia is lowering 99.3 percent of its tariffs on imports from the United States and eliminating a slew of longstanding non-tariff barriers, while accepting a 19 percent tariff on exports to the United States. South Korea is accepting US auto standards along with a 15 percent tariff. Vietnam

pledged to lower all of its tariffs and barriers in exchange for a 20 percent rate. Most countries we are negotiating with have also agreed to cooperate on economic security to ensure the safety and reliability of our critical supply chains.

Countries are also committing to upgrade and better enforce their labor standards, tackling arbitrage that has put American workers and producers at a disadvantage. Multiple countries will join the United States (along with the E.U., Mexico and Canada) in banning the importation of goods made with forced labor. Eliminating global slavery was a longstanding goal of advocates and policymakers, but it was the leverage of President Trump's tariffs that finally made it possible to unlock meaningful progress.

Similarly, countries are agreeing to improve resource efficiency and enforcement of environmental laws, including in the most problematic sectors, such as illegal logging, illegal fishing and the illegal wildlife trade. The international trade system should not force Americans to compete with those who use our responsible capitalism against US as a competitive advantage.

Importantly, these commitments are actionable, and the United States will enforce them. Rather than the drawn-out dispute settlement process favored by the old guard of trade bureaucrats, the new US approach is to closely monitor implementation of the deals and swiftly reimpose a higher tariff rate for noncompliance if needed. President Trump uniquely recognizes that the privilege of selling into the world's most lucrative consumer market is a mighty carrot. And a tariff is a formidable stick.

At the World Trade Organization, enacting changes to trade rules requires total consensus among nations. In fact, the last attempt at serious reform, known as the Doha Round, failed because protectionist nations refused to take down their trade barriers to the United States. Moreover, our adversaries relish blocking reform. They prefer a status quo that feeds an exploding US trade deficit, sapping this nation of the industrial might that made it, and keeps it, a superpower.

But the rules of international trade cannot be a suicide pact. By imposing tariffs to rebalance the trade deficit and negotiating significant reforms that form the basis of a new international system, the United States has shown bold leadership to address what policymakers long considered intractable problems.

Many of these deals also come with significant investment commitments into US productive capacity, such as \$600 billion in the case of the European Union and \$350 billion by South Korea. These investments, 10 times larger than the inflation-adjusted value of the Marshall Plan that rebuilt Europe after World War II, will accelerate US reindustrialization. South Korea will help reinvigorate the American shipbuilding industry, which has atrophied in the face of nonmarket competition. These types of investments are on top of purchase commitments that cumulatively account for almost \$1 trillion of American energy, agriculture, defense and industrial products. This demand for American goods and ready access to capital will allow American manufacturing to reassert leadership across strategic sectors where we have fallen behind.

Skeptics point out that tariffs, although once a fixture of American economic policy, have not been used this extensively for generations. But we now have data showing that the failure to use tariffs or similar protections created an economy that was heavy on finance and consulting fees and low on the lasting wealth and security that come from making things. Even among those who agree with that diagnosis, some say the president's remedy is too strong or was administered too hastily, or that the tariffs will be too disruptive in the short term. This is not the time to debate how many angels can dance on the head of a pin. This is an emergency. We know what the problem is and we know how to address it. There is no time to waste.

President Trump has already shown that he can implement tariffs and other economic tools to reshape supply chains and reinvigorate manufacturing. When he deployed sweeping tariffs in his first term, not only did the sky not fall as pundits predicted, but inflation actually went down. And now that he is imposing tariffs even more broadly, inflation remains in check. A long-term problem

won't be fixed overnight, and the process may not always be smooth, but the situation demands strong and resolute action to strengthen the US indUStrial base.

It took over 50 years from that first meeting at Bretton Woods until the creation of the W.T.O. It has been 30 years since. Fewer than 130 days from the beginning of the Trump Round, the Turnberry system is by no means complete, but its construction is well underway.

Stagflation Discussion

Stagflation talk has taken center stage. It should be remembered that stagflation in the 1970s was driven by crude oil prices increasing from \$3.56 per barrel in August 1973 to \$10.11 per barrel in January 1974 to \$14.85 per barrel in January 1979 to \$39.50 per barrel in May 1980. In less than seven years crude oil price increased by over 1,100 percent. By comparison, the current crude oil price is approximately half the May 2022 price. With almost every country expanding energy production, lower energy prices could occur.

According to the prolonged price decrease in crude oil and natural gas, inflation numbers will be below macro-economic models. This is because energy is incredibly important as it impacts inflation numbers directly, such as fuel and as a feedstock in petrochemicals, and indirectly, such as an increased cost that a manufacturer and business must recoup. Energy costs impact input prices for production, and every other stage required to reach the consumer with each cost increase being pushed to the next level. The cumulative impact of higher energy prices on the consumer tends to be understated by macro-economic models.

One inflationary outcome from lower energy prices is discretionary income increasing, which allows for more spending. The other outcome is the producer price index will show a decline with retail sales prices staying firm and retailers performing better than if it was still a higher energy cost environment. Any economic downturn will force retailers to lower prices to move products.

The inflationary impact of the massive increase in the money supply has worked its way through the economy, resulting in a natural slowdown. It is difficult to have runaway inflation with lower energy prices, and a weak housing market.

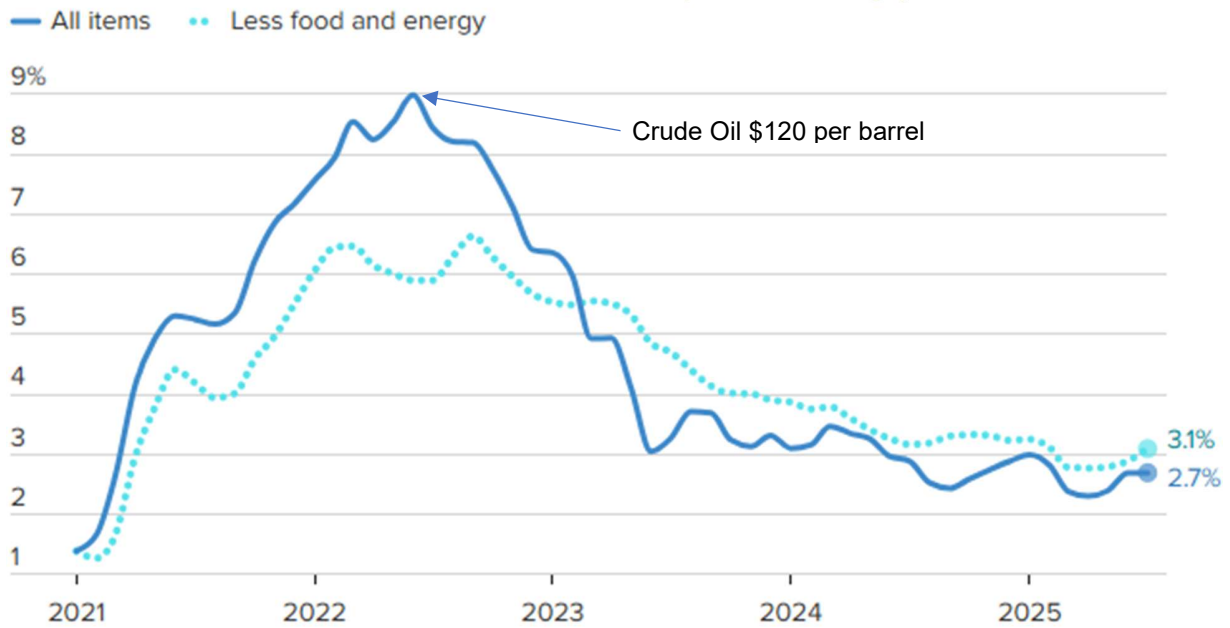
During the last trade war, the rate of inflation decreased. It is not a forgone conclusion that the rate of inflation is going to increase. The consumer price index increased a seasonally adjusted 0.2 percent for the month and 2.7 percent on a 12-month basis, the Bureau of Labor Statistics reported. That compared with the respective Dow Jones estimates for 0.2 percent and 2.8 percent.

Excluding food and energy, the core CPI increased 0.3 percent for the month and 3.1 percent from a year ago, compared with the forecasts for 0.3 percent and 3 percent. Federal Reserve officials generally consider core inflation to be a better reading for longer-term trends. The monthly core rate was the biggest increase since January while the annual rate was the highest since February.

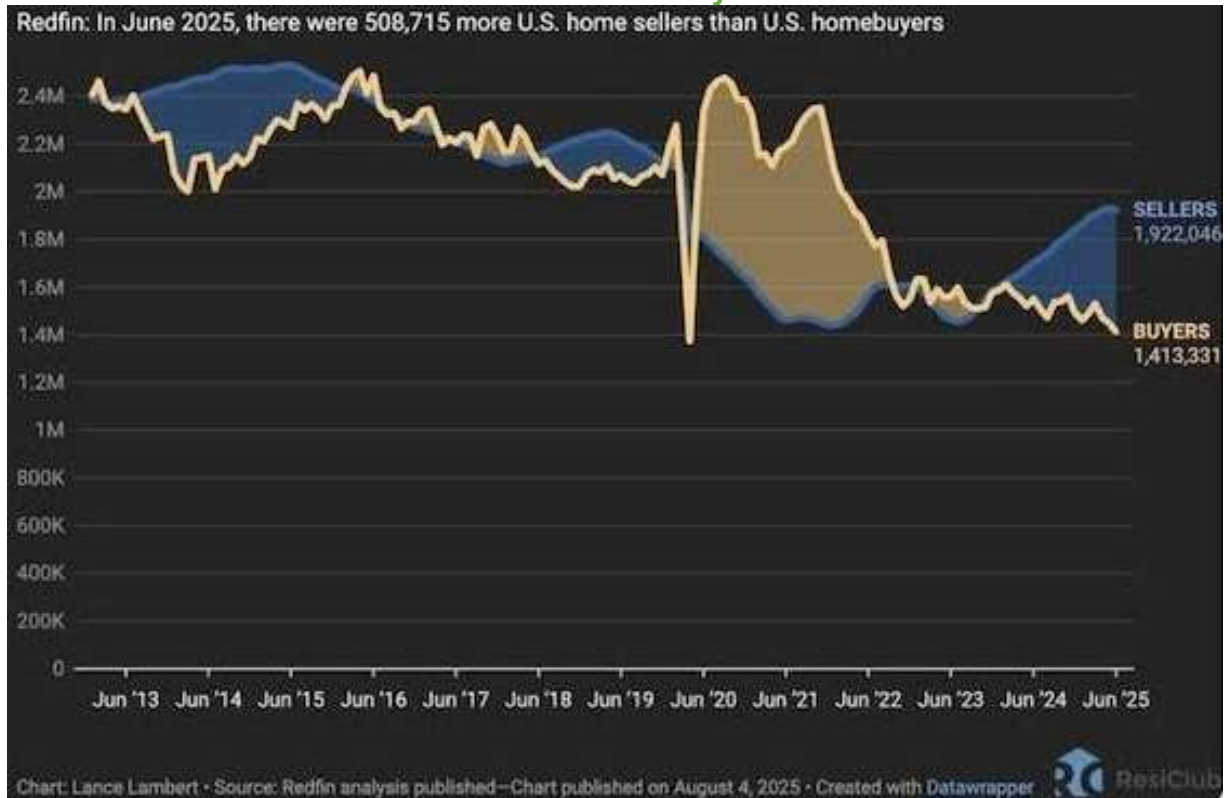
Tariff-sensitive new vehicle prices also were unchanged. For now, automakers are choosing to keep market share.

A 0.2 percent increase in shelter costs drove much of the rise in the index, while food prices were flat and energy fell 1.1 percent, the BLS said. US housing market now 508,715 more home sellers than homebuyers. With the current housing market experiencing pain, it is easier to envision lower prices not higher prices.

US Consumer Price Index (Annual Change)



Estimated Number of Homebuyers and Sellers



Mid-America Manufacturing Slumps for July

After six straight months of above growth neutral readings, the Creighton University Mid-America Business Conditions Index, a leading economic indicator for the nine-state region stretching from Minnesota to Arkansas, sank below 50.0 growth neutral threshold for July.

Overall Index

The Business Conditions Index, which uses the identical methodology as the national Institute for Supply Management (ISM) and ranges between 0 and 100 with 50.0 representing growth neutral, declined to 49.4 for July from 50.7 in June.

“Creighton’s latest survey continues to reflect job losses across the region, accompanied by elevated wholesale inflation,” said Ernie Goss, PhD, Director of Creighton University’s Economic Forecasting Group and the Jack A. MacAllister Chair in Regional Economics in the Heider College of Business. “Supply managers expressed growing concern that rising tariffs could further accelerate inflationary pressures. Despite these concerns, only 6.7 percent of surveyed supply managers reported shifting purchases from international to domestic suppliers in response to the tariffs.”

Employment

The July employment index fell to 45.4 from 49.4 in June, marking the fourth consecutive month below the growth-neutral threshold of 50. This sustained weakness reflects ongoing labor market challenges in the regional manufacturing sector.

“The Creighton survey has now recorded six straight months of job losses across the nine-state Mid-America region,” said Goss. “While employment rose in the first quarter, driven by increased production ahead of anticipated tariff impacts, the last four months have signaled a return to regional manufacturing job declines,” said Goss.

US Bureau of Labor Statistics data show that the region shed 12,900 (-0.9 percent) manufacturing jobs over the past 12 months. The US lost 89,000 (-0.7 percent) manufacturing jobs over the same time period.

Comments from Supply Managers in July:

- “Most of the suppliers I work with are dropping their production down to four-day work weeks. Nothing like a 20 percent cut in pay.”
- “I believe that the President’s tariff changes are going to help our country to be better trading partners. It will take a bit of time for it all to shake out though.”
- “No changes to international purchases until a final tariff rate is in place. Certain products have been put on hold.”
- “We are not accepting pricing increases and have any tariffs added as a surcharge, so they are easy to remove.”
- “Long-term contracts have been key to holding pricing steady. Where there are extreme cost pressures with suppliers, collaboration on a resolution is the method of choice, while rare.”
- “While the Trump administration is doing everything possible to bring the economy back to its former glory, the democrats continue their seditious acts to block any attempts at dismantling their previous criminal maneuvers to destroy this great country! A reckoning is coming.”

Wholesale Prices

The July price gauge climbed to 69.7 from 67.9 in June. “The regional inflation yardstick has moved into a range indicating that inflationary pressures are moving higher at the wholesale level. However, due to a

slowing regional and US economies, I expect the Federal Reserve to cut interest rates at its September 16-17 meetings,” said Goss.

On average, supply managers expect tariffs to push input prices up by 7.8 percent over the next 12 months. This is up from 7.5 percent recorded in June.

Confidence

Looking ahead at the next six months, economic optimism, as captured by the July Business Confidence Index, dropped to 42.6 from June’s 50.0. “Concerns regarding tariffs and slowing new orders pushed supply managers’ expectations lower. Only one in six supply managers expect rising economic conditions for their firm over the next six months,” said Goss.

Inventories

The regional inventory index, reflecting levels of raw materials and supplies, increased to 49.1 in July from June’s 46.9. “Rapid expansions in inventories in the first quarter are now being offset by monthly pullbacks in buildups,” said Goss.

Trade

Recent uncertainty regarding tariffs and trade restrictions pushed new export orders lower for the last four months. New export orders slumped to 38.3 from 43.4 in June. As a result of record imports for the first two months of 2025, supply managers pulled back on purchasing from abroad in the last five months. The July import index increased to a still weak reading of 36.3 from 30.0 in June.

Supply managers were asked about their firm’s reactions to tariffs and threats of tariffs. Only 6.7 percent of manufacturing supply managers reported switching from international suppliers to domestic suppliers. More than one-third, or 67.0 percent, reported making no changes of suppliers due to tariffs. The remaining 26.3 percent indicated that their firms had switched from one international supplier to another international input supplier.

According to US International Trade Administration (ITA) data, the regional economy exported \$38.9 billion in manufactured goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$40.8 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 4.7 percent decline. In terms of export gainers, North Dakota registered the top percentage gain with a 42.6 percent addition, and South Dakota recorded the largest percentage loss with a 19.9 percent reduction in the export of manufactured goods.

Other Survey Components of the July Business Conditions Index

New orders dropped to 45.5 from 52.4 in June; the production or sales index increased slightly to 49.0 from 48.5 in June; and the speed of deliveries of raw materials and supplies rose to 57.8 from June’s 56.5. Higher readings indicate slower deliveries and/or rising supply chain disruptions or delays.

Arkansas

The state’s July Business Conditions Index fell to 43.0 from 48.2 in June. Components from the July survey of supply managers were new orders at 43.7, production or sales at 47.0; delivery lead time at 53.1; inventories at 39.5; and employment at 31.8. According to ITA data, the Arkansas manufacturing sector exported \$2.3 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$2.4 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 5.6 percent decline.

Iowa

The state's Business Conditions Index for July declined to 43.7 from 48.0 in June. Components of the overall July index were new orders at 43.9; production or sales at 47.3; delivery lead time at 53.6; employment at 33.2; and inventories at 40.6. According to ITA data, the Iowa manufacturing sector exported \$6.2 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$6.9 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 10.3 percent decline.

Kansas

The Kansas Business Conditions Index for July increased to 51.1 from 49.9 in June. Components of the leading economic indicators from the monthly survey of supply managers for July were new orders at 45.5; production or sales at 50.3; delivery lead time at 58.6; employment at 47.7; and inventories at 58.6. According to ITA data, the Kansas manufacturing sector exported \$5.0 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$5.2 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 3.5 percent decline.

Minnesota

The July Business Conditions Index for Minnesota dropped to 49.3 from 52.8 in June. Components of the overall July index were new orders at 45.1; production or sales at 49.8; delivery lead time at 57.5; inventories at 50.2; and employment at 44.3. According to ITA data, the Minnesota manufacturing sector exported \$9.5 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$10.7 billion for the same period in 2024, for an 11.4 percent decline.

Missouri

The state's July Business Conditions Index rose to 51.8 from 50.8 in June. Components of the overall index from the survey of supply managers for July were new orders at 45.6; production or sales at 50.6; delivery lead time at 59.1; inventories at 54.4; and employment at 49.2. According to ITA data, the Missouri manufacturing sector exported \$7.0 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$7.1 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 0.5 percent decline.

Nebraska

The state's July Business Conditions Index climbed to 51.6 from June's 51.3. Components of the index from the monthly survey of supply managers for July were new orders at 45.5; production or sales at 50.4; delivery lead time at 58.8; inventories at 53.6; and employment at 48.3. According to ITA data, the Nebraska manufacturing sector exported \$2.7 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$3.1 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 10.8 percent decline.

North Dakota

The state's Business Conditions Index advanced above growth neutral for a 13th consecutive month to 52.2 from 52.0 in June. Components of the overall index for July were new orders at 45.7; production or sales at 50.8; delivery lead time at 59.4; employment at 50.0; and inventories at 55.0. According to ITA data, the North Dakota manufacturing sector exported \$2.5 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$1.8 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 42.6 percent gain.

Oklahoma

The state's Business Conditions Index for July declined to 49.0 from 50.6 in June. Components of the overall July index were new orders at 45.0; production or sales at 49.5; delivery lead time at 57.2; inventories at 49.7; and employment at 43.7. According to ITA data, the Oklahoma manufacturing sector

exported \$2.9 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$2.6 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 3.5 percent gain.

South Dakota

The July Business Conditions Index for South Dakota slumped to 44.5 from 48.5 in June. Components of the overall July index were new orders at 44.1; production or sales at 47.6; delivery lead time at 54.1; inventories at 42.1; and employment at 34.8. According to ITA data, the South Dakota manufacturing sector exported \$0.7 billion in goods for the first five months of 2025, compared to \$0.9 billion for the same period in 2024, for a 19.9 percent decline.

Corn

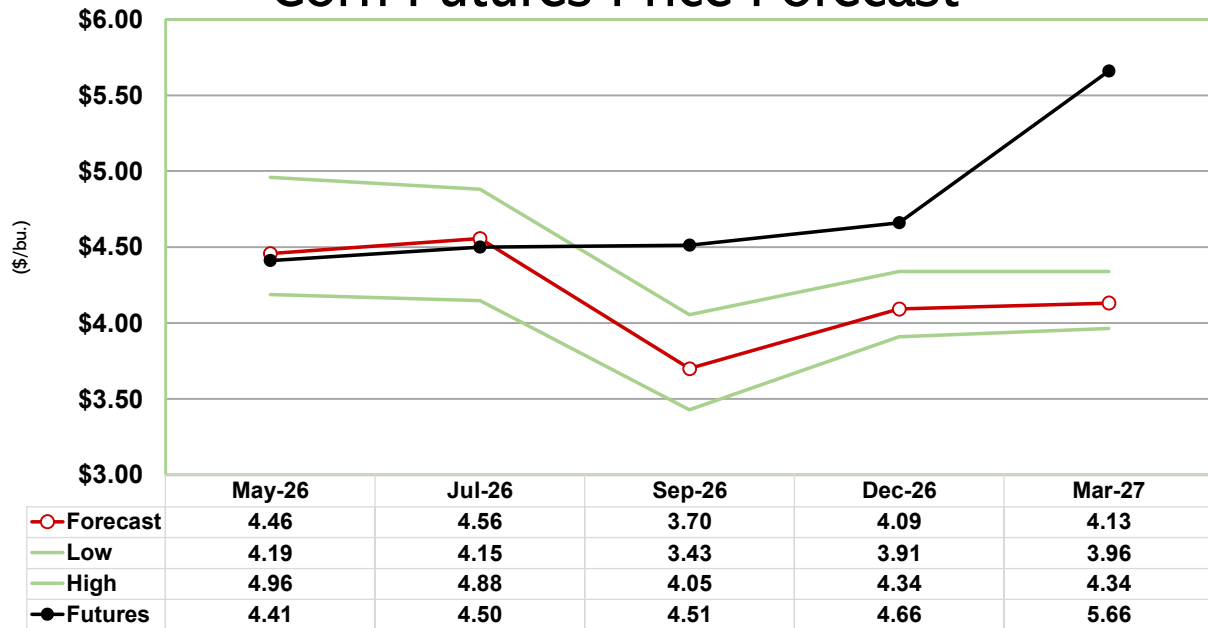
Fundamental Recommendation: Sell strength into the \$4.55–\$4.65 range, particularly in deferred 2026 contracts, as the forecast places the seasonal price peak in mid-2026 before easing into the second half of the year and finishing below current deferred pricing.

- Fundamental Bullish Factor –** Ethanol production softened marginally but remains structurally supportive, with plants operating near seasonal norms and stabilizing nearby demand.
- Fundamental Bullish Factor –** Export inspections remain well ahead of last year's pace, supporting the recent increase in USDA export demand.
- Fundamental Bearish Factor –** US corn remains uncompetitive into parts of Asia as Brazilian FOB values undercut US origin, increasing pressure as South America moves deeper into peak export season.
- Fundamental Bearish Factor –** Global supply remains ample following WASDE, with large Brazilian and Argentine production capping deferred upside.
- Fundamental Swing Factor –** Developments in US biofuel policy, including SAF-related incentives, remain a potential upside risk to ethanol demand forecasts and could alter forward balance sheet expectations.
- Fundamental Swing Factor –** US export competitiveness depends on the pace of Brazil's harvest and new-crop availability.

Technical Recommendation: Sideways to Lower.

- Technical Bullish Factor –** Relative strength indicators approaching oversold levels, suggesting short-term stabilization risk.
- Technical Bullish Factor –** Chart support is developing just below current levels, limiting immediate downside follow-through.
- Technical Bullish Factor –** Commercial buying interest has emerged near recent lows, helping stabilize prices despite broadly bearish longer-term signals.
- Technical Bearish Factor –** Prices remain within a broader downtrend on the daily chart.
- Technical Bearish Factor –** Futures are still trading below key moving averages, limiting upside momentum on rallies.
- Technical Bearish Factor –** Longer-term structure remains bearish.

Corn Futures Price Forecast



Corn (continued)

US CORN SUPPLY AND DEMAND (million acres/million bushels)

	2025/26			2026/27		
	USDA	Change from January	HB	USDA	Change from January	HB
Planted Area	98.8	-	98.7	-	-	95.0
Harvested Area	91.3	-	90.2	-	-	86.7
Yield	186.5	-	185.3	-	-	187.0
Beginning Stocks (Sep. 1)	1,551	-	1,532	-	-	2,070
Production	17,021	-	16,709	-	-	16,213
Imports	25	-	30	-	-	30
Total Supply	18,597	-	18,270	-	-	18,313
Feed and Residual	6,200	-	6,400	-	-	6,475
Food, Seed, and Industrial	6,970	-	6,850	-	-	6,885
Ethanol and By-products	5,600	-	5,450	-	-	5,450
Domestic Total	13,170	-	13,250	-	-	13,360
Exports	3,300	100	2,950	-	-	3,100
Total Use	16,470	100	16,200	-	-	16,460
Ending Stocks (Aug. 31)	2,127	(100)	2,070	-	-	1,853
Stocks/Use	12.9%	-0.7%	12.8%	0.0%	0.0%	11.3%
Farm Price (\$/bu.)	\$4.10	\$0.00	\$4.24	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$4.25

CBOT Corn Technicals

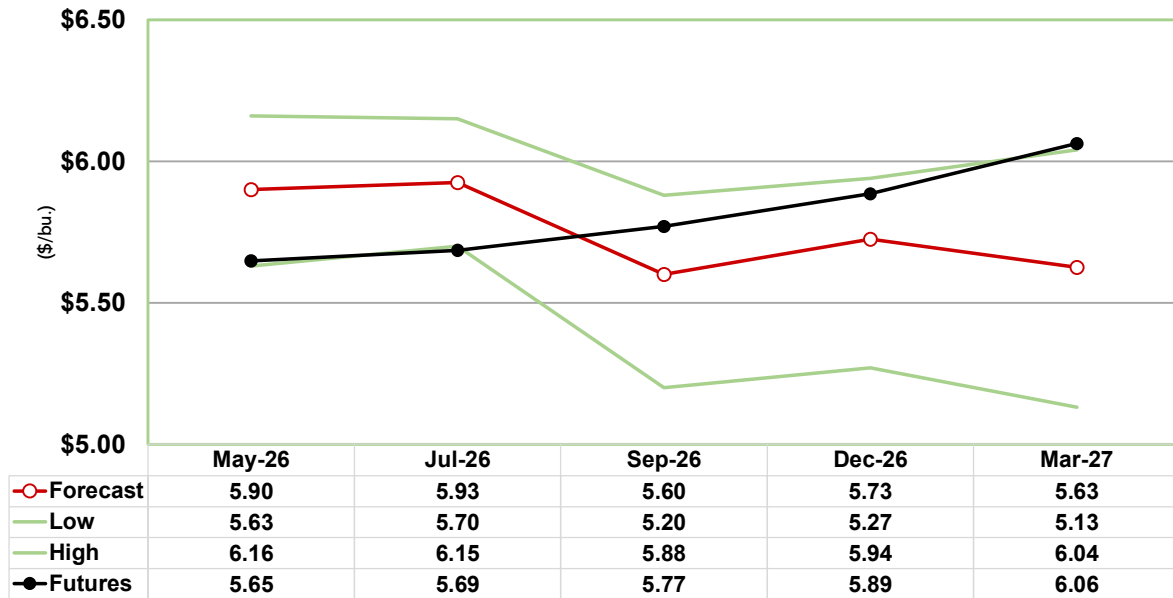


Wheat

Fundamental Recommendation: Sep-26 wheat futures are projected to gravitate toward the \$5.50–\$5.65 range, favoring a sell-rallies approach rather than a trend-driven short. While the forecast shows modest stabilization into year-end after a late-summer dip, we view current strength as largely technically driven and not supported by a tightening global balance.

- Fundamental Bullish Factor –** US wheat exports remain modestly ahead of last year's pace, helping stabilize basis.
- Fundamental Bullish Factor –** Dryness in portions of the Southern Plains remains a conditional risk, allowing for a modest weather-related premium if winter conditions deteriorate further.
- Fundamental Bearish Factor –** Global ending stocks remain elevated, reinforcing excess supply among major exporters.
- Fundamental Bearish Factor –** Russian wheat continues to undercut global competitors, keeping US offers at a disadvantage in most international tenders.
- Fundamental Swing Factor –** Winter weather risks remain fluid, prolonged dryness or limited snow cover could quickly alter market sentiment.
- Fundamental Swing Factor –** Weekly export sales will determine whether momentum can be maintained.
- Technical Recommendation:** Sideways to Lower.
- Technical Bullish Factor –** Short-term momentum oversold, raising bounce risk.
- Technical Bearish Factor –** SRW and HRW prices well below key 40-day moving averages.
- Technical Bearish Factor –** SRW and HRW prices in downtrends on daily charts.
- Technical Bearish Factor –** Down-trending corn market is bearish for wheat.

Wheat Futures Price Forecast



Wheat (continued)

US WHEAT SUPPLY AND DEMAND (million acres/million bushels)

	2025/26			2026/27		
	USDA	Change from January	HB	USDA	Change from January	HB
Planted Area	45.3	-	45.3	-	-	45.0
Harvested Area	37.2	-	37.2	-	-	37.0
Yield	53.3	-	49.5	-	-	52.5
Beginning Stocks (Jun. 1)	855	-	851	-	-	900
Production	1,985	-	1,985	-	-	1,943
Imports	120	-	130	-	-	130
Total Supply	2,959	-	2,965	-	-	2,973
Food	967	(5)	970	-	-	970
Seed	61	0	65	-	-	65
Feed and Residual	100	-	105	-	-	105
Domestic Total	1,128	(5)	1,140	-	-	1,140
Exports	900	-	925	-	-	930
Total Use	2,028	(5)	2,065	-	-	2,070
Ending Stocks (May 31)	931	5	900	-	-	903
Stocks/Use	45.9%	0.3%	43.6%	0.0%	-	43.6%
Farm Price (\$/bu.)	\$4.90	\$0.00	\$5.60	\$0.00	-	\$5.75

CBOT Wheat Technicals

Soybeans

Fundamental Recommendation: With futures trading near the upper end of the model's mid-year value band and the forecast projecting a seasonal dip toward the low-\$10s into early fall before stabilizing into year-end, strength continues to present structured hedge opportunities rather than outright bullish exposure, particularly with Brazil's production now institutionally confirmed near 176 mmt. While the board is currently trading near modeled mid-year values, firm basis levels and record domestic crush argue against aggressive outright shorts, making paired sales with inexpensive low-delta call coverage the preferred structure.

Fundamental Bullish Factor – Domestic crush demand remains exceptionally strong, with processors maintaining firm bids and national basis levels well supported.

Fundamental Bullish Factor – Recent US flash sales to China confirm opportunistic buying when spreads turn favorable.

Fundamental Bearish Factor – Combined Brazilian and Argentine soybean production could approach 230 mmt, putting sustained pressure on forward pricing if dryness in southern Brazil eases.

Fundamental Bearish Factor – Global export competition remains intense as Brazilian shipments accelerate, limiting US export recovery during peak South American flow.

Fundamental Swing Factor – The trajectory of Chinese purchasing into year-end remains the key wildcard for short-term price direction and spread support.

Fundamental Swing Factor – South American weather remains critical: persistent dryness in southern Brazil offers support, but a return to more normal rainfall could quickly erode the weather premium currently priced into the curve.

Technical Recommendation: Sideways to Slightly Lower.

Technical Bullish Factor – Prices now above key 40-day moving average.

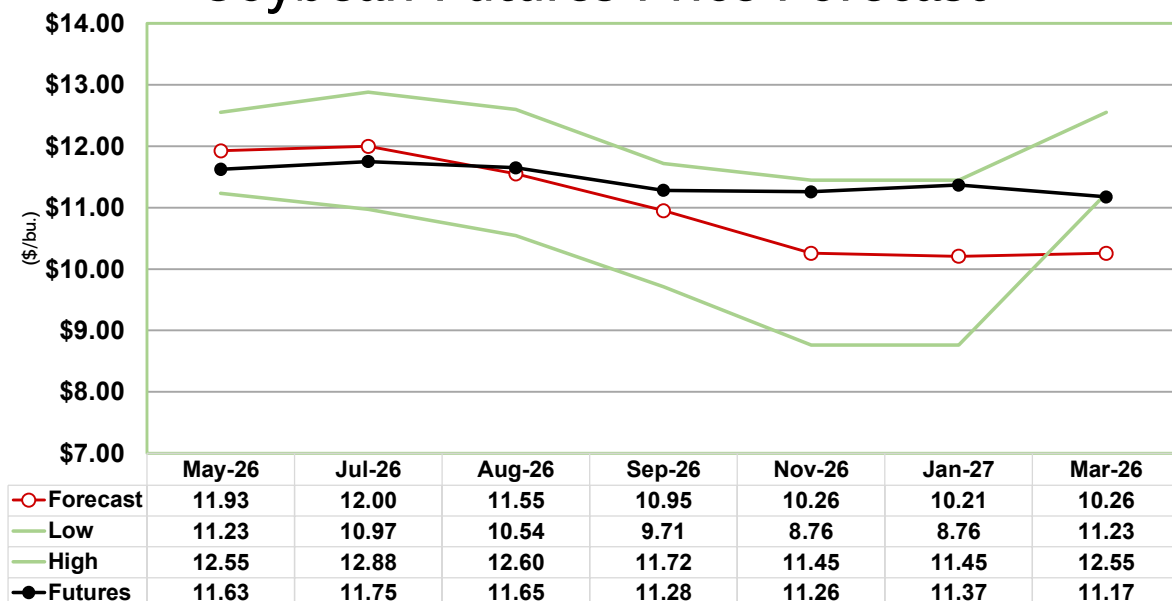
Technical Bullish Factor – Soybean meal market now performing much better.

Technical Bullish Factor – MACD indicator turns bullish.

Technical Bearish Factor – Slumping corn and wheat markets are bearish for beans.

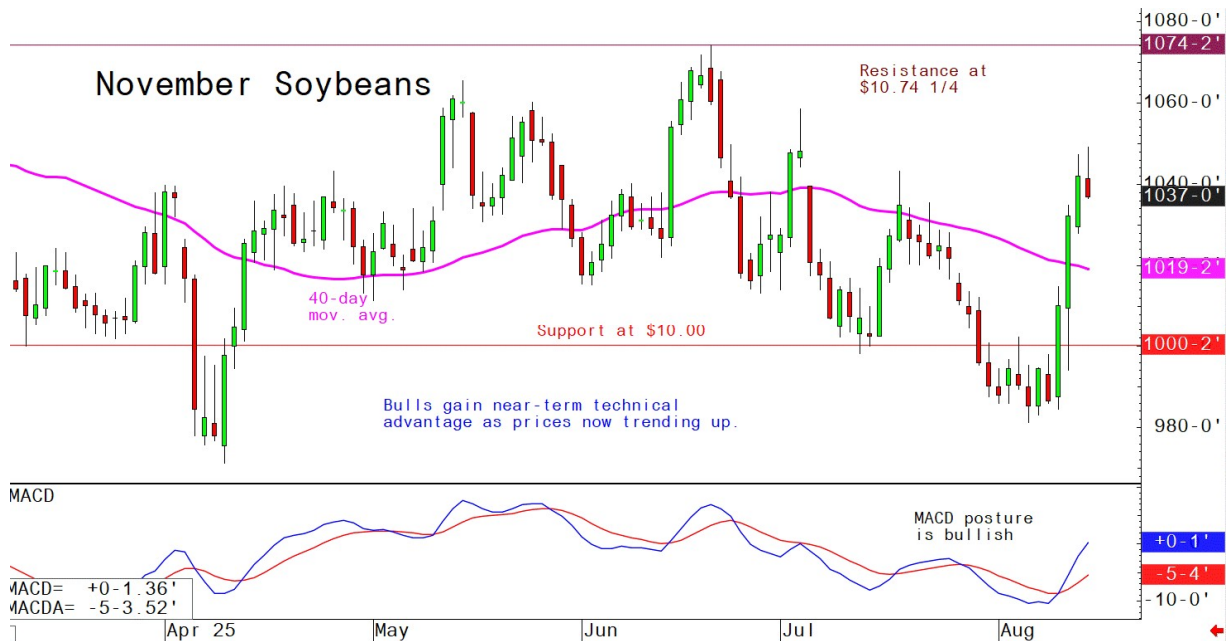
Technical Bearish Factor – Longer-term charts are not friendly for beans.

Soybean Futures Price Forecast



Soybeans (continued)**US SOYBEAN SUPPLY AND DEMAND (million acres/million bushels)**

	2025/26			2026/27		
	USDA	Change from January	HB	USDA	Change from January	HB
Planted Area	81.2	-	81.0	-	-	86.0
Harvested Area	80.4	-	80.0	-	-	84.9
Yield	53.0	-	53.9	-	-	50.5
Beginning Stocks (Sep. 1)	325	-	316	-	-	369
Production	4,262	-	4,310	-	-	4,287
Imports	20	-	25	-	-	25
Total Supply	4,607	-	4,652	-	-	4,684
Crush	2,570	-	2,520	-	-	2,570
Exports	1,575	-	1,650	-	-	1,660
Seed	73	-	77	-	-	77
Residual	39	-	36	-	-	36
Total Use	4,257	-	4,282	-	-	4,343
Ending Stocks (Aug. 31)	350	-	369	-	-	341
Stocks/Use	6.9%	0.0%	8.6%	0.0%	0.0%	7.9%
Farm Price (\$/bu.)	\$ 10.20	\$0.00	\$ 10.25	\$ -	\$ -	\$ 10.75

CBOT Soybeans Technicals

Soybean Meal

Fundamental Recommendation: With current futures trading near the upper end of the modeled Q2–Q3 value range and the forecast projecting a seasonal trough in the upper-\$270s before recovering toward the \$295–\$305 range later in the year, rallies into the \$310–\$325 zone continue to favor disciplined hedge initiation rather than outright bullish exposure. Short exposure should remain structured and risk-defined given the potential for weather-driven volatility, but price levels currently reflect premium relative to modeled mid-year fundamentals.

Fundamental Bullish Factor – Elevated cattle prices continue to support protein substitution toward pork and poultry, indirectly sustaining soybean meal feed inclusion.

Fundamental Bullish Factor – Robust US crush rates are supporting steady domestic meal demand, even as expanding processing capacity limits the scope for sustained meal tightness.

Fundamental Bearish Factor – A large South American crop will increase global meal availability and intensify export competition for the US in 2025/26.

Fundamental Bearish Factor – Renewable diesel-driven oil margins continue to incentivize elevated crush rates, mechanically expanding meal supply even if domestic meal demand remains stable

Technical Recommendation: Sideways to lower.

Technical Bullish Factor – Prices now trending up on daily bar chart.

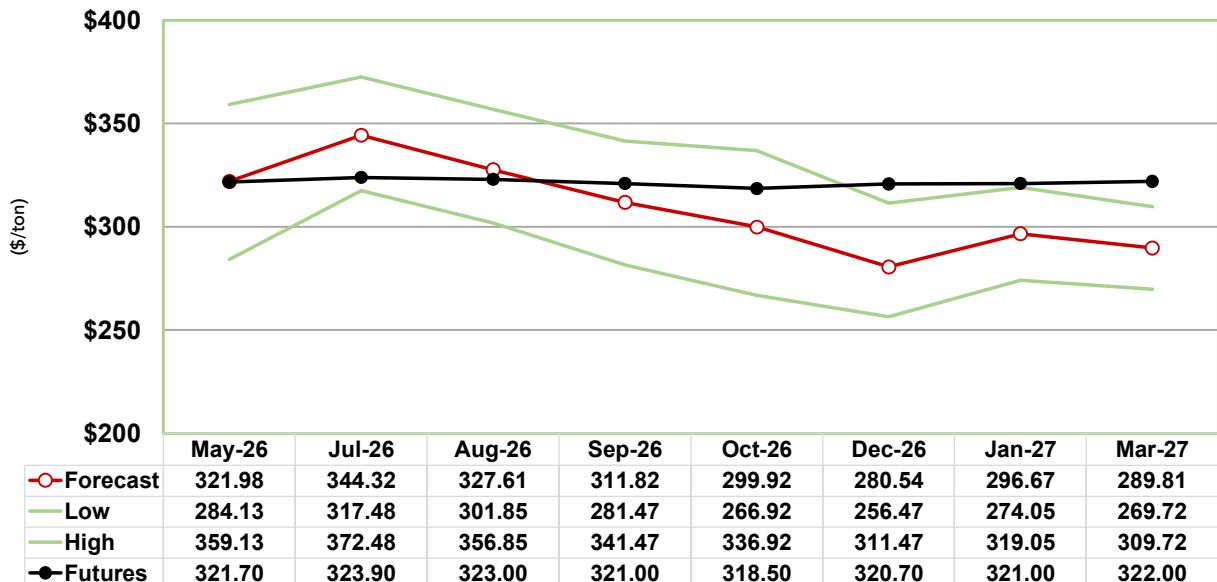
Technical Bullish Factor – Prices above key 40-day moving average.

Technical Bullish Factor – Spreaders are unwinding short meal, long bean oil spreads.

Technical Bearish Factor – Market is short-term overbought, technically.

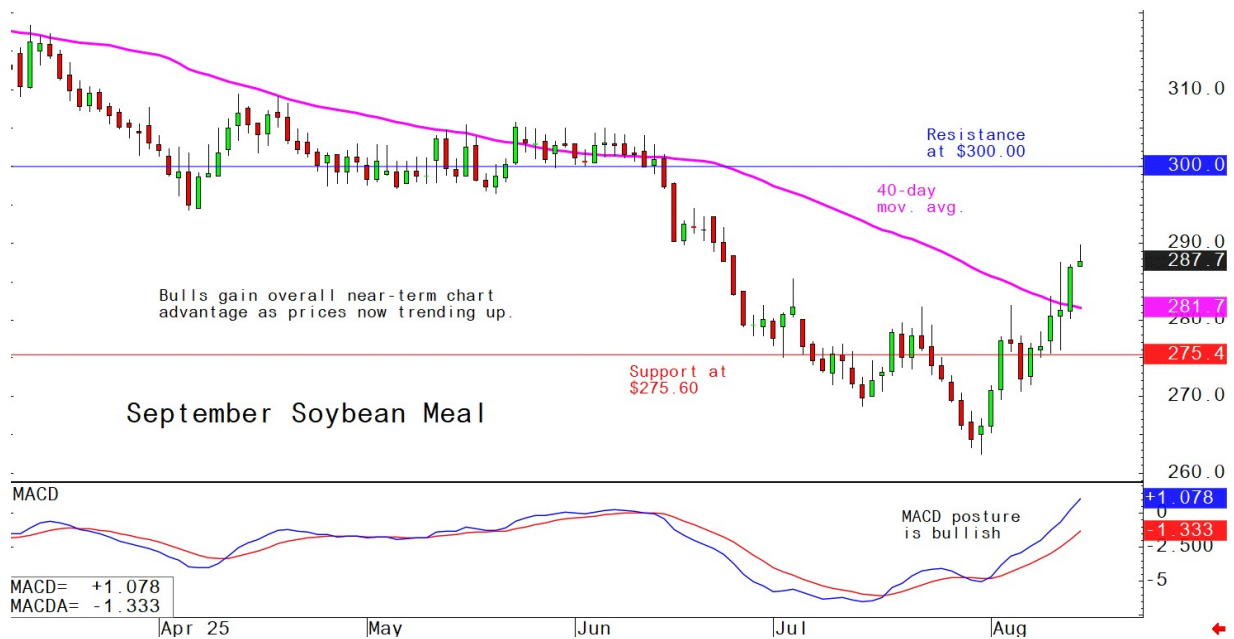
Technical Bearish Factor – Longer-term charts are not bullish.

Soybean Meal Futures Price Forecast



Soybean Meal (Continued)**US SOYBEAN MEAL SUPPLY AND DEMAND (000 tons)**

	2025/26			2026/27		
	USDA	Change from January	HB	USDA	Change from January	HB
Beginning Stocks (Oct. 1)	398	-	450	-	-	543
Production	60,752	-	59,818	-	-	62,989
Imports	725	-	625	-	-	600
Total Supply	61,875	-	60,893	-	-	64,132
Domestic Use	42,025	-	41,100	-	-	43,200
Exports	19,400	-	19,250	-	-	20,300
Total Use	61,425	-	60,350	-	-	63,500
Ending Stocks (Sep. 30)	450	-	543	-	-	650
Decatur (48 pct., \$/ton)	\$ 295	\$0	\$ 275	\$ -	\$ -	\$ 270

CBOT Soybean Meal Technicals

Soybean Oil

Fundamental Recommendation: Soybean oil futures remain near the upper end of modeled value for the balance of 2026, with the forecast projecting a gradual decline from the mid-50s toward the mid-40s into year-end. Current pricing continues to reflect biofuel-driven premium and cross-commodity support from the broader soy complex rather than tightening oil fundamentals. Rallies into the upper-50s favor disciplined hedge initiation or risk-defined short exposure, while outright buying should remain tactical and limited to weather-driven volatility rather than structural strength.

Fundamental Bullish Factor – Renewable diesel and biodiesel demand continue to provide baseline structural support, though margin volatility has prevented sustained upside follow-through.

Fundamental Bullish Factor – Weather-sensitive palm oil production remains a watchpoint; any supply disruptions could tighten the global veg oil balance and lift soybean oil prices.

Fundamental Bearish Factor – A confirmed 176 mmt Brazilian soybean crop materially expands global vegetable oil supply in 2025/26, reinforcing competitive pressure on US soybean oil pricing.

Fundamental Bearish Factor – Depressed crude oil prices weigh on biofuel margins and typically correspond with seasonally weaker biodiesel output, capping near-term price potential.

Technical Recommendation: Sideways to Lower.

Technical Bullish Factor – Solid chart support levels just below the market.

Technical Bullish Factor – Rallies in soybeans and meal will limit downside in bean oil.

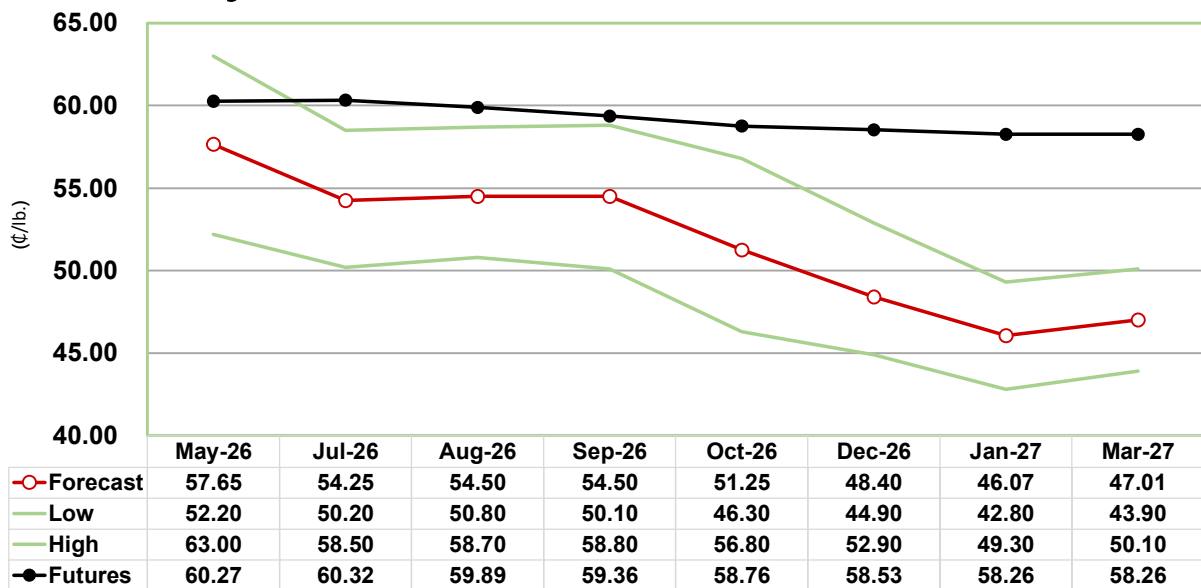
Technical Bullish Factor – Weekly chart remains constructive despite the shorter-term downtrend.

Technical Bearish Factor – Price downtrend in place on daily chart.

Technical Bearish Factor – Prices below key 40-day moving average.

Technical Bearish Factor – Slumping crude oil prices bearish for bean oil.

Soybean Oil Futures Price Forecast



Soybean Oil (Continued)**US SOYBEAN OIL SUPPLY AND DEMAND (million pounds)**

	2025/26			2026/27		
	USDA	Change from January	HB	USDA	Change from January	HB
Beginning Stocks (Oct. 1)	1,747	-	1,751	-	-	1,726
Production	29,940	-	29,811	-	-	30,500
Imports	365	-	500	-	-	250
Total Supply	32,052	-	32,062	-	-	32,476
Domestic Use	29,100	-	29,586	-	-	29,800
Biofuel	14,800	-	15,086	-	-	15,300
Food, Feed, Other Industrial	14,300	-	14,500	-	-	14,500
Exports	1,200	-	750	-	-	800
Total Use	30,300	-	30,336	-	-	30,600
Ending Stocks (Sep. 30)	1,752	-	1,726	-	-	1,876
Decatur (crude, ¢/lb.)	53.00	0.00	48.00	0.0	0.0	49.0

CBOT Soybean Oil Technicals

Agricultural Prices

	This Week 3/4/2026	Last Week 2/25/2026	Year Ago 3/4/2025
Corn:			
Processor Central, IL \$/bu.	4.39	4.27	4.38
Omaha, NE, \$/bu.	3.92	3.87	4.09
DDGs:			
Northeast, IA, \$/ton	147.50	147.50	151.67
Northwest, IA, \$/ton	152.78	152.30	147.33
Soybeans:			
Processor Central, IL \$/bu.	11.67	11.42	9.99
St. Louis, MO, \$/bu.	11.85	11.66	10.16
Soybean Meal:			
Decatur, IL, 48 pct, ton	322.93	308.90	298.70
Wheat:			
Kansas City, MO, HRW, \$/bu.	5.48	5.34	5.62
Minneapolis, MN, 14 pct, DNS, \$/bu.	7.15	7.15	8.29
St. Louis, MO, SRW, \$/bu.	5.66	5.65	5.44
Portland, OR, SWW, \$/bu.	6.07	6.03	6.19
Northeast MT, No. 1 HAD, \$/bu.	5.62	5.59	6.88
Sorghum:			
Processor Kansas City, MO (\$/bu)	3.49	3.43	3.81
Cotton:			
ET-ST, 41-4-34, cents/lb.	60.36	59.64	57.74
Rice:			
AR, Long Grain, \$/cwt.	10.74	9.90	13.43
Barley:			
MT, feed, \$/cwt.	3.44	N/A	3.00
Oats:			
Minneapolis, MN, No.2, heavy, \$/bu.	3.76	3.74	4.21
Sunflower:			
Fargo, ND, High Oleics, \$/cwt.	23.25	22.50	27.00
Hogs:			
National Base, \$/carcass wt.	N/A	91.28	89.21
Feeder Pigs:			
National Avg., 40 lbs., \$/head	125.88	126.61	126.61
Choice Steers:			
NE, \$/cwt.	242.01	247.40	197.81
Feeder Cattle:			
Oklahoma City, Steers, 750-800 lb.,	376.33	370.52	274.55
Oklahoma City, Steers, 500-550 lb.,	482.17	519.71	369.34
Oklahoma City, Steers, 450-500 lb.,	536.78	566.06	382.34
Milk:			
Class III, CME Futures, Spot Month,	17.65	16.62	18.25
Ethanol:			
IA, \$/gal.	1.60	1.61	1.61
Farm Diesel:			
Midwest, \$/gal.	3.14	3.14	2.96
Fertilizer			
DAP Tampa, \$/tonne	828.44	828.44	735.22
Urea New Orleans, \$/tonne	581.00	581.00	550.60
UAN New Orleans, \$/tonne	435.18	435.18	348.88